OCT. 12, 2026

TIME

The Admiral

U.S. Pacific Commander **Samuel Paparo**'s force covers half the earth's surface. His goal? Winning without fighting

by **RICHARD HALL**

TIME

[October 12th, 2026]

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Business

- **How We Chose the 2026 TIME Executives of the Year: Tech and Data**
  The inaugural list recognizes 50 business leaders that are shaping the future of technology.
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Business | Executives of the Year: Tech & Data

How We Chose the 2026 TIME Executives of the Year: Tech and Data

At a moment when emerging technologies are driving both the global economy and the news cycle, business leaders must not only keep up with an industry moving at a breakneck pace—they must look around the corner at what's next. That's why TIME is publishing its first-ever Executives of the Year: Tech & Data list, recognizing 50 leaders shaping the future of technology, artificial intelligence, cybersecurity, and digital innovation across industries.

See the full 2026 list here.

Among them are Bartley Richardson, CrowdStrike's chief AI and autonomous systems officer, who is heading up a new AI research lab dedicated to building autonomous cybersecurity systems, and Reddit chief technology officer (CTO) Amit Puntambekar, who is shepherding AI adoption at one of the internet's largest repositories of human conversation. At pharmaceutical giant Eli Lilly & Co.,

Diogo Rau oversaw the effort to build a supercomputer called LillyPod, which models biological processes and screens potential molecules before promising candidates enter wet lab experiments. Meanwhile, at OpenAI, Vijaye Raji, CTO of applications, is in charge of key technical teams—such as data, experimentation, and growth—that help power the ubiquitous ChatGPT, as well as the coding tool Codex.

To create the list**,** our editors and reporters across the newsroom evaluated the scale of each leader's responsibilities, the significance of the investments and initiatives they oversee, and their demonstrated impact on how their organization operates, competes, and grows. What came together was a group of executives tasked with modernizing legacy systems and digital infrastructure. Those leaders include Monica Caldas, Liberty Mutual's global chief information officer, who is rewiring the century-old insurance company for what she calls "the intelligence era," and Ogi Redzic, who joined Caterpillar Inc. as SVP and chief digital officer in 2018 and has helped the equipment manufacturer rebuild itself around data to address customers' labor and safety issues.

The list also highlights the creation of new or expanded roles designed to meet the fast-evolving moment. There's Kathleen Grace, named Lionsgate's first-ever chief AI officer in February and the first Hollywood studio executive to hold that particular title, as well as Delta's Amala Duggirala, who joined the airline in January as EVP and chief digital and technology officer—a brand-new role overseeing its recently combined digital and technology organizations, encompassing both the enterprise technology that powers its global operations and the digital tools it creates for customers and employees alike.

Beyond the U.S., tech executives across Asia, Africa, and Europe are driving innovation. At Singapore-based Grab, CTO Suthen Thomas Paradatheth has helped the company transition from a ride-

sharing platform to a superapp that processes millions of transactions a day across Southeast Asia. Felix Ike, co-founder and CTO of the Nigerian fintech company Moniepoint, has helped to establish the business as one of Africa's leading financial platforms. At Paris-based Back Market, a global online marketplace for refurbished electronics, CTO Dawn Baker is applying an environmental mission to the company's use of computing power. "We have to make sure we're not using more than we need," she says. "It's about using AI smartly and not falling for the hype."

These leaders and their fellow honorees are the catalysts of some of the most consequential transformations taking place across modern enterprise—translating innovation into meaning.

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https://time.com/article/2026/09/22/how-we-chose-executives-of-the-year-tech-data/

Airbnb CEO Brian Chesky Thinks He Can Make Cities More Affordable

Next year, Airbnb will mark its 20th anniversary. Through its evolution—from a few air mattresses placed on an apartment floor to one of America's best-known American technology companies—it has been led by Brian Chesky. And at a time when Silicon Valley doesn't champion introspection, Chesky, 45, is an outlier: someone who has become a prominent voice on company leadership and a frequent investigator of his own character. "The primary weakness of me as a founder running a company was people had to pay for my immaturity in my thirties," he told me during a recent interview at Airbnb's headquarters in San Francisco for our new interview series, The CEO Moment. "But I said it was a good long-term bet," We spoke as the company, called out by critics as contributing to rising housing costs in the cities where it operates, was set to announce a number of new housing initiatives.

You are one of three people who started the company in 2007. There aren't that many founders leading Fortune 500 companies. How do you think the fact that you founded this company shapes how you lead it today?
The people that build companies tend to be more in the details, more decisive, bigger authority, …They tend to take bigger, bolder risks partly because they have the moral authority to. For example, I could—I wouldn't—but I could change the name of the company because I came up with the name of the company. Somebody who is a professional manager, I don't think they would ever dare change the name of their company. They would feel like it's not theirs to change.

You've said that you think CEOs think about hiring wrong. Why is that?

Because I thought about hiring wrong…When I was starting Airbnb…Sam Altman…said hiring should be 50% of your job. I'm not even sure it was 50% of his job.

Has your thinking about the value of remote work shifted as we've gotten further from the pandemic?
I have a view that if your office policy's is easy to explain, it might be wrong because it might be one size fits all.

You're vocal about the fact that you think leaders don't need to have regular one on one meetings with their direct reports.
I think it's not only unnecessary, it's probably inferior. And if you go through the list of great CEOs, almost none of them that I'm aware of do recurring one-on-ones…

Now you can get a hotel on Airbnb. Why?
I was ideologically against hotels. In fact, I think our first tag line was "forget hotels." So why would I ever offer them? And so that was my party line for probably 10 years. In 2018, 2019 my stubbornness got the best of me and many of our customers told us that we want hotels. And ultimately I had to make a decision. You know if you're a brand, just because your customer wants something doesn't mean you sell it to them. You can decide no, go somewhere else…But we noticed there were three types of people. There are people that only book Airbnbs. There are people that only book hotels, but most people are willing to book both.

You're building your own AI frontier lab separate from Airbnb. Why not build that within Airbnb and what will be the relationship between the two?
I thought about building inside of Airbnb….I like to think that our shareholders know what they get themselves into, and I never sold them on us being a frontier company and spending billions and billions of dollars of capital expenditure and then spending huge sums recruiting these engineers or these AI researchers….The benefit to Airbnb and to me is I'm gonna learn a lot about AI, but

it's also a totally different kind of culture. So I wanted to keep them separate.

You're announcing a number of new initiatives around housing. People say Airbnb makes cities more expensive. What role do you want the company to play in making places more affordable?
I think Airbnb has been a place people pointed to over the last 15 years, especially the last decade…for reasons why cities are expensive. And so we have wanted to be part of the solution, not part of the problem.

We're creating a $250 million fund to house the last dollar for projects. There's about 750,000 homes in America development projects that are stalled because they don't have the last dollar of completion ... .We want to do something called the City Index. We want to open source data around cities, policies, the cost of living, permitting to basically show the cities that are most successful at lowering housing costs by having the best policies….We want to do the housing prize where we're going to do a million dollar prize every year for five years for any company, private or or nonprofit that has ideas around technology that can make housing development easier.

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https://time.com/collection/the-ceo-moment/2026/airbnb-brian-chesky/

Climate

- **Why California Just Declared a State of Emergency Due to El Niño**
  A super El Niño could bring extreme weather to the state this winter.

Climate | extreme weather

Why California Just Declared a State of Emergency Due to El Niño

California's governor Gavin Newsom has declared a state of emergency ahead of a potentially historic El Niño. In a statement released Sept. 22, Newsom said the declaration is meant to ensure communities have the resources they need to handle the impacts expected this winter.

"California is strongest when we look out for one another. That is what this action is about," Newsom said. "Giving communities the support they need, giving first responders the tools to do their jobs, and giving families the confidence that their state is ready."

Read more: *How Should You Prepare For A Super El Niño?*

The state of emergency allows the government to mobilize state resources: readying flood-fighting supplies such as sandbags and pumps, preparing the National Guard to assist with flood response and search and rescue efforts, and fortifying roads and infrastructure. State environmental and natural resources agencies will also fast-track permitting and engage in other efforts to better prepare for flooding and landslides.

How will El Niño impact California?

El Niño typically brings wetter, more intense winters to California—which could leave the state more vulnerable to severe winter storms, heavy rainfall, landslides, and flooding. An El Niño year does not guarantee that these conditions will occur, but it does increase the likelihood.

Climate change is also supercharging weather events, and El Niño is no exception. One study published in August found that El Niño events are now nearly 40% stronger than before the Industrial era. This year's El Niño is predicted to be the strongest in recorded history.

What impacts has California already felt from this year's El Niño?

The governor's office noted that the state has already experienced coastal flooding attributable to El Niño. The state can expect to see Kelvin waves, slow moving pulses of water that can stretch thousands of miles and raise sea levels along the coastline—increasing the risk for coastal flooding and erosion, and offshore Pacific hurricanes. Climate scientists also warn that the Pacific can expect to see a temporary 6-inch to 2-ft. rise in sea levels this winter.

A number of southern California towns, including Malibu, Laguna Beach, and Long Beach, have already seen significant coastal erosion due to El Niño and Pacific hurricanes this year.

How can Californians prepare for El Niño?

The state has urged residents to take action to prepare for El Niño by signing up for emergency alerts and learning their flood risk, and having an evacuation plan and emergency kit at the ready.

It's all part of an effort to ensure that the state is not caught off guard by El Niño. "We are not waiting for this season's storms to be on our doorstep," Cal OES director Caroline Thomas Jacobs said in a statement. "By planning early and coordinating resources ahead of El Niño, we are working to ensure communities and first responders have the personnel, equipment, and support they need to

prepare for severe weather, respond quickly when conditions change, and protect lives and property across California.”

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https://time.com/article/2026/09/23/california-state-of-emergency-el-nino/

Health

- **More Americans Are Losing Health Insurance—And Everyone Will Pay**
  As people lose health insurance coverage, experts warn of more crowded hospitals and higher costs for everyone.
- **A Genetic Mutation May Help Explain Lung Cancer in Nonsmokers**
  A rare genetic mutation could help to explain why some people who don’t smoke still develop lung cancer.

Health | Health Care

More Americans Are Losing Health Insurance—And Everyone Will Pay

People waiting for care in a crowded hospital emergency room in Coon Rapids, Minn.Michael Siluk/UCG/Universal Images Group—Getty Images

Dr. Elaine Batchlor, CEO of MLK Community Hospital in Los Angeles, already knows what will happen if her hospital closes. All she has to do is remember King Drew, a similar safety net hospital that provided care to a large share of low-income patients in the same neighborhood, that closed in 2007 because of safety and quality problems. The low-income neighborhoods in South Los Angeles were without a hospital for almost a decade.

As a result, other hospitals in the area saw higher volumes of patients and more uninsured patients; one hospital's share of uninsured patients more than tripled, from about 13% to nearly 45%, a study found. This redistribution of sick people led to severe overcrowding in other hospitals and higher costs for insured patients.

Now, Batchlor and many other hospital administrators are bracing for this dynamic once again as cuts from H.R. 1, also known as the One Big Beautiful Bill Act, ripple across the U.S. health care system. H.R. 1 makes it more difficult for people to stay on Medicaid by introducing work requirements and by demanding that people re-confirm their income and address every six months, rather than every year. It also reduces the amount of state funding hospitals receive through the Medicaid program. Batchlor estimates that her hospital will lose between $80-$100 million a year because of H.R. 1.

She's scrambling to find funding from elsewhere, including from a new 5% sales tax recently passed in Los Angeles County to fund local health services, including safety net hospitals like hers. She's determined to keep MLK Community Hospital open, but she knows other hospitals won't be successful in doing so. One analysis found that more than 300 rural hospitals are at risk of closing because of H.R. 1.

What Batchlor wants people to know is that an increase in uninsured people doesn't just affect the people losing insurance. It affects everyone. More uninsured people means more of a financial burden on hospitals—particularly hospitals like hers, which are located in low-income neighborhoods and which will incur higher costs treating everyone who shows up in the emergency room because they'll see more uninsured patients. When hospitals face financial distress, they cut back on services: often ob-gyn and preventative care.

Or they close altogether. "There will be hospitals that will likely close as a result of the financial distress, and the patients that were served by those hospitals will need to go somewhere else," she says. "They will go to hospitals in other neighborhoods, and those emergency departments will become more crowded, and those hospitals will become more crowded."

What's more, people with insurance are likely to see their costs rise as the number of uninsured Americans spikes. Hospitals and doctors must charge more as they provide more non-reimbursed care. A September 2 report by Marsh, the consulting firm formerly known as Mercer, estimates that the cost of health insurance plans to employers will increase by 11% in 2027—the biggest jump in decades—and that many employers will pass those costs on to their workers. "Lower government funding and reimbursements in public health programs are also driving higher charges or care in employer plans," the report found.

Why the health-insurance landscape is changing so quickly

The U.S. is facing its most serious health-insurance crisis since the passage of the Affordable Care Act in 2010. It's not just that H.R. 1 is projected to make more people lose Medicaid coverage; Congress decided not to renew subsidies for the Affordable Care Act in 2026, meaning that thousands of families are seeing the cost of insurance skyrocket and are deciding to drop insurance coverage rather than pay hundreds or thousands of dollars a month for care. All told, the Congressional Budget Office expects 16 million more people to be uninsured by 2034.

People who will not have health insurance may forgo primary care, checkups, and other preventative measures, and could be saddled with hundreds of thousands of dollars in bills if they get a serious illness. But it's not just bad news for them—the insurance crisis threatens the finances and care of everyone, even if they have private insurance plans and are sure they won't lose coverage, experts say. Everyone is likely to face longer wait times, fewer services, and higher costs as hospitals and medical systems sag under the weight of more uninsured. And as the example of MLK Community Hospital shows, they may also be paying higher taxes

on products that aren’t even health related to help fund care for the uninsured.

“There’s a ripple effect that hits the uninsured and newly uninsured and underinsured particularly hard,” says Anthony Wright, executive director of Families USA, a national consumer health advocacy group. “But it ripples through families and communities and the health system we all rely on.”

Some hospitals are already closing. Select Specialty Hospital—Tucson East recently announced its imminent closure, though a spokesperson did not confirm it was because of H.R. 1. Others are already making tough choices about what services to continue. One Las Vegas hospital said in August that because of increased demand for its emergency room services, it was closing its maternity and NICU services by the end of September.

How hospitals absorb the costs

Safety net hospitals are most in danger of seeing their finances erode quickly. That’s because they are, by definition, non-profit hospitals that provide care to people regardless of their insurance status or ability to pay. America’s Essential Hospitals, an association for safety net hospitals, said in an interview that among its 400 members, three-quarters of the patients they serve are uninsured or on Medicare or Medicaid. Already, these hospitals are losing money every year, says Jennifer DeCubellis, president and CEO of America’s Essential Hospitals. This is likely to get worse as more people delay care and then end up in emergency rooms, where their care is going to be more expensive, she says. “We're going to see longer wait times in emergency departments,” she says, “and what we've already started seeing, even before the One Big Beautiful Bill, is the loss of services in local communities.”

For-profit hospitals are also seeing a surge in uninsured patients stressing their finances. Executives at HCA Healthcare, the nation’s

largest for-profit hospital chain, said on an earnings call in July that individuals who had lost coverage because ACA subsidies disappeared were now showing up at hospitals uninsured. Other for-profit hospitals are also reporting large increases of uninsured patients seeking care.

When hospitals have more uninsured patients, they have to absorb the costs of providing that care. They then often pass those costs onto insured patients by charging insurers more for services, studies have found.

“One of the reasons our premiums have been increasing for employee-sponsored health care is that hospitals that do charity care get a tax benefit, but they also add the cost of their unfunded care to the prices they charge to employee-sponsored health care,” says Heidi Russell, director of the Center for Health Policy at the Baker Institute at Rice University.

What happens when people lose insurance

Rena Healy, 30, is one uninsured patient who is doing everything she can to avoid turning up in an emergency room, even though she has a heart condition that requires her to be on $1,000-a-month medicine she can’t afford. She was on Medicaid in Indiana, but recently moved to Tennessee to be near her fiance. Tennessee, unlike Indiana, has not expanded Medicaid, and Healy suddenly found herself unable to qualify for health insurance.

Her career as a video game developer doesn’t make her enough money to pay the $500 a month that a plan on the Affordable Care Act marketplace would cost, she says. So she’s looking for a job that provides health insurance, including as a cashier or certified nursing assistant, even though her heart condition means she’s not supposed to do physical work.

She’s been applying for more than 100 jobs a week but hasn’t found anything yet, she says, and meanwhile is running to the end of her medication supply from when she was in Indiana. For now, Healy is leaning on public clinics for appointments and trying to avoid going to the ER, even though she knows that the monitor implanted in her sternum could show her heart rate going up to 250 bpm, which would necessitate an ER visit. “I sympathize with people who don’t want to go to the ER or take an ambulance even if they’re dying,” she says. “They don’t want to cash-strap their family.”

Healy is one example of what can happen when people lose insurance; unable to get preventative care, they can’t manage their symptoms as effectively. One study of the Medicaid expansion in the South found that when more people gained health insurance, health declines in low-income adults slowed down because they were able to seek preventative care.

Avoiding health care for financial reasons ends up being more expensive in the long run; when people skip preventative care, they end up sicker by the time they go to the doctor, often in an ER.

“It’s $2,500 to do a colonoscopy, but it’s $130,000 to treat someone for Stage IV colon cancer,” says Dr. Erik Mikaitis, CEO of Cook County Health, one of the largest public health systems in the nation. Already, Cook County Health—which runs two hospitals and a dozen community health centers in Chicago, while also providing health care to the Cook County Jail—has seen an increase from 19% of patients being uninsured to 25%, just since January. Mikaitis is worried that instead of managing patients’ diabetes and high blood pressure, doctors will be seeing more patients with strokes and heart attacks in the emergency department.

As a result, he predicts, people going to the emergency room for anything will see longer wait times, especially as health systems

close clinics and hospitals that are losing money.

“This isn’t just a Medicaid problem,” he says. “There’s going to be this cascade of failure in terms of access. You’re going to see people in the hallways waiting to be seen.”

Hospitals won’t just be more crowded. They’ll also be forced to cut back on preventative services and those that help keep people out of the emergency room, says David Perlstein, the president and CEO of SBH Health System. For instance, SBH, which is located in the Bronx, has a violence interrupter program for teens and a boxing program that makes communities safer for young people.

“As we erode our margin, we may have to pull back services at some point,” he says. “We’re not doing it yet. But if this continues and there is no change, we’re going to have to make some very difficult decisions in the near future.”

It’s something that Batchlor worries about, too. Only about 3-5% of patients at MLK Community Hospital have private insurance, she says, so it can’t just raise rates on privately insured patients to make up for a surge in uninsured. The hospital has won accolades for its diabetes management program, which is bringing down the need for amputations, and for its wound care program, which has helped people stay out of the emergency room. But she’s worried about the health system’s ability to be able to provide that kind of preventative care.

“We'll all be worse off for having let people get sicker and end up needing more expensive care—ending up with amputations, ending up on chronic dialysis,” she says. “None of that is really what we should be doing as a society. It's not financially effective, and it's not humane.”

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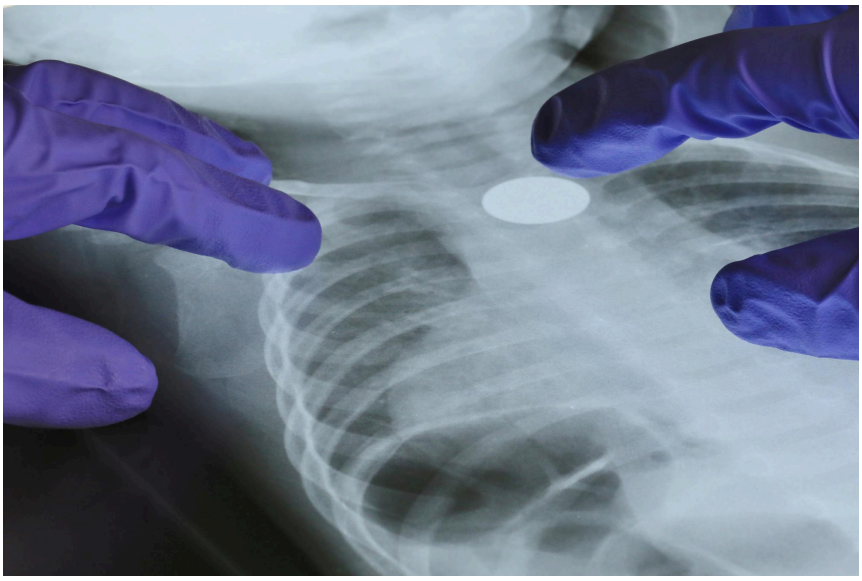
https://time.com/article/2026/09/08/losing-health-insurance-affects-everyone/

Health | Cancer

A Genetic Mutation May Help Explain Lung Cancer in Nonsmokers



Douglas Sacha—Getty Images

Smoking is one of the biggest contributors to lung cancer, but anywhere from 10-20% of cases in the U.S. each year are diagnosed in people who never smoked. In a new study published in *Science*, researchers report that for some of those cases, an inherited genetic mutation might be involved.

Scientists co-led by Dr. Jaclyn LoPiccolo, an attending physician and lung-cancer researcher at Dana Farber Cancer Institute, found that people with a mutation in the EGFR gene had a 25-fold higher risk of developing lung cancer compared to people without the mutation, regardless of whether they smoked. When the researchers looked just at nonsmokers, the risk was even higher: carriers of the mutation had a 60-fold higher risk compared to nonsmokers who didn't have the mutation. Since nonsmokers have a lower chance of developing lung cancer than smokers, this jump in risk reflects how strongly this genetic mutation might impact risk, LoPiccolo says.

The findings add to growing knowledge about what is driving lung cancer in people who don’t smoke. A handful of genetic mutations have been linked to lung cancer in nonsmokers, including some that appear to be more prevalent in Asian people who get lung cancer, as well as inherited mutations like BRCA2, but they aren't well understood. While the specific EGFR mutation in question, called T790M, was first discovered in a European family in 2005 with members who hadn't smoked but had developed lung cancer, it wasn’t clear how much the mutation, which is rare, actually contributed to lung cancer.

LoPiccolo and her team used a large data set of genetic samples from the 23andMe Research Institute to determine how much of an impact the mutation has on lung cancer. “While we knew that T790M was associated with lung cancer, we didn’t have a population large enough to determine how common the variant was, how strong its effect, and how the risk varies in different groups,” says LoPiccolo. “This mutation is so rare that we weren’t able to get population-level risk estimates without the size of a database like that from 23andMe.” About one in 15,000 people in the U.S. carry the mutation, but rates are higher—about one in 2,000—in Southern Appalachia, where scientists believe the first carrier brought the mutation to the U.S. from England or Ireland more than 200 years ago.

The findings open to door to considering how genetic testing might fit into lung-cancer screening. Currently, screening—in which people receive a low-dose radiation CT scan to look for lung cancer—is only recommended for people with a heavy smoking history who are above a certain age. “I do think that understanding your risk of lung cancer, especially from a genetic perspective, along with your exposures to things like radon and other environmental factors, would be really valuable,” says Nadia Litterman, executive director of the Susan Wojcicki Foundation, which funded the Lung Cancer Genetics Study that provided data for the analysis. (Wojcicki, the former CEO of YouTube, never smoked, yet she

died of lung cancer in 2024.) “That’s the world we are trying to work toward, and this is a major step toward that.”

Litterman points to BRCA genetic testing for breast cancer as a potential model for lung cancer. “The lung-cancer guidelines are not quite there yet, but it’s a pretty clear path of what it could look like for people who are carriers of this mutation,” she says. “They could be screened on a more regular basis, and if they develop cancer, and it’s caught early, they would have a much better trajectory than if they didn’t know about [their genetic] risk.”

That’s what patients like Frank McKenna are counting on. A personal trainer in Virginia Beach, McKenna was diagnosed with lung cancer in 2016, despite never smoking or working in areas where he might have been exposed to environmental risk factors like radon. “I was shocked when I was diagnosed with Stage IV lung cancer after the only symptom I had was a little cough,” the 66 year old says. His doctor ordered a genetic test of fluid drained from his lung and learned he carried the EGFT T790M mutation. A biopsy from his lung lesion confirmed the mutation, and he started on a targeted therapy, which he continues today, designed to specifically neutralize his mutation. “When I started that targeted therapy, which is a pill I take once a day, within a couple of days, I could feel a difference,” he says. “I had lost weight, and there was cancer in various parts of my body, including in my bones, where it had spread. But I could feel my life coming back.”

A few months later, his daughter, who is now 33, was diagnosed with melanoma in her ear and was asked about her family history of cancer. She joined a study and provided samples to look for markers of cancer, and while she did not carry many common cancer mutations, she did carry T790M. But for now, there are no evidence-based recommendations to follow when it comes to how she should be monitoring her lungs for signs of cancer. “That’s why I’m pushing for how we can screen younger people, knowing that she has a genetic risk, and what low-dose screening she should

get," says McKenna. "If something were to appear, she can catch it at an early stage, perhaps Stage I, and not go through Stage IV, because there are not as many options, and the outlook is not as positive."

LoPiccolo is conducting a study, called INHERIT, which includes people from across the country with any inherited genetic risk for lung cancer, including the EGFR T790M mutation. Doctors will work with each participant to understand their family history of lung cancer, smoking history, genetic profile, and any environmental exposures that might contribute to lung cancer before coming up with a personalized plan for how often they should be screened with low-dose CT scans to look for cancer. "The goal is to use CT screening to detect lung cancer at the earliest, most curable stage when it can be removed or cured," says LoPiccolo.

Such data will be critical to changing lung-cancer screening guidelines and providing families like the McKennas more peace of mind that they are giving themselves the best chance of conquering cancer. "I have scans every six to seven months," says McKenna. "Because when you read any research on targeted therapies, one of the first things they say is that cancer will find a way to overcome the therapy. Fortunately, my last scan a few weeks ago was still clear, but what if you could catch the cancer early with screening often enough so it's much easier to treat?"

Correction, Sept. 17

The original version of the story misstates the funder of the study. The study was funded by a group of philanthropic organizations and a government grant, not the Susan Wojcicki Foundation, which funded the Lung Cancer Genetics Study, which provided data included in the study.

https://time.com/article/2026/09/17/genetic-mutation-lung-cancer-nonsmokers/

Ideas

- **We Have a Climate Imagination Problem**
  We're missing an emotional architecture for change: how it feels to want a different future and believe we can reach it, writes Solitaire Townsend.
- **Philanthropy Must Build the Architecture of Hope**
  Philanthropy is not measured by the wealth we give away but by the futures we make possible, by the dreams that become reality because someone built something lasting.
- **How to Read the Room**
  Everyone gets told to read the room. Almost no one gets taught how, writes Pamela Meyer.

Ideas | climate

We Have a Climate Imagination Problem

Solitaire Townsend is a climate entrepreneur, author, and solutionist.

Megane Adam—Getty Images

Solitaire Townsend is a climate entrepreneur, author, and solutionist.

Earlier this year I stood in a draughty sports hall, facing rows of 10-year-olds sitting cross-legged on the scuffed floor. I asked them a question: “What does climate change mean?”

Small hands shot up: “The sea rises and floods everything,” one child said. “Fires are gonna burn all the forests,” another added. “We all die.”

The litany of apocalypse continued until I interrupted with a second question. “And what can we do about it?”

Silence.

After some shuffling, one girl tentatively offered: “Solar panels?” Then a louder boy called out, “Recycle!” His classmates nodded.

And that was pretty much it.

I've worked in climate communication for nearly 30 years, interspersing sessions with CEOs, activists, and politicians with talks to school kids. Over those decades, I’ve watched the average 10-year-old acquire an increasingly sophisticated picture of the climate crisis they will inherit. They can imagine burning forests, flooded cities, dying species, and an uninhabitable planet. Many of them seem to understand climate science better than some CEOs.

But ask these children to picture what we do about it, and suddenly their extraordinary imaginations contract to a recycling bin.

To be clear, I am enthusiastically in favour of recycling—just not as our answer to a planetary emergency. But I understand why I’m still hearing that inadequate response. Since the greenhouse effect and global warming first entered mainstream public consciousness in the 1980s, we’ve offered people ever more detailed maps of the apocalypse with barely a sketch of the way out.

The climate movement, of which I’m a proud member, has been complicit in this communications crisis. Most messages shared by progressive forces are merely an ad nauseam echo of: climate change is real, humans are to blame, and the consequences are catastrophic. I call this framing the earned dystopia, and it’s so ubiquitous most pre-teens can parrot it.

After so many years, can we not imagine a different story?

One reason for this imagination deficit is that storytelling has been treated as merely the spoonful of sugar to help the scientific medicine go down. Storytellers are asked to act as the marketing department for climate science.

But if that subservient role for storytellers was ever needed, it's increasingly futile now that climate change has started communicating itself. Our growing count of horrifying floods, fires, storms, and droughts capture headlines without my help.

We have clear science and brutal direct experience of climate change, so why haven't politicians and populations sprung into action?

The logic of the climate crisis is clear. What we're missing is the magic.

Long before humans measured atmospheric carbon, we whispered tales of flood and fire. Stories have always helped us understand who we are and what we might become. Increasingly, researchers are proving this singular power of stories to spark ideas, possibilities, and acts of imagination.

I believe part of this magic comes from stories' purpose in curating emotions rather than evidence.

Today, we don't particularly lack information about heat pumps, electric vehicles, or regenerative agriculture. More details than you could ever want are just a click away. What we're missing is an emotional architecture for change; how it feels to want a different future and to believe we can reach it.

That's where great storytelling could change everything. Our ability to enter a story and temporarily experience the character's world as our own is called narrative transportation. Studies prove that this experience of emoting along with fictional people can directly influence real people's attitudes, intentions, and even our behaviors. Few other mechanisms can achieve the same effect.

Climate politics has sensed this power, but translated it into the narrower language of "public narrative." Politicians now plot

narratives for electrification and renewables. Campaigners construct counter-narratives to fossil fuels. Brand teams test sustainability narratives against each other. In climate circles, everyone is searching for the breakthrough narrative that will finally unlock action. But too often the term is simply a cypher for messaging. And messaging is not the same thing as mythology.

A political narrative tells us how to understand an issue while mythology helps us understand ourselves. And climate change is mythological in scale. It contains terrifying monsters, underdog heroes, unexpected allies, destruction and rebirth. Or at least it should. My problem is with the enormous cultural library of apocalyptic narratives compared to a surprisingly small shelf of fables that foreshadow a better ending.

We need a plot twist in climate storytelling, moving beyond the threat and into the thrilling adventure of solving it. Tales of the messy decades in which billions of people change how they power homes, grow food, travel, build cities, and protect one another from a climate that has already changed

That's a job for storytellers.

Culture makers are beginning to catch on. I've been invited by television and film writers, social-media creators, and brands to help climate solutions appear in comedy, drama, adventure, and everyday life. Ever more box-office hits, like *The Wild Robot*, *Avatar*, and the upcoming *Digger*, reflect our fight against climate and nature crises. *Sesame Street* is helping kids cope with extreme weather. New climate fiction novels weave answers into stirring worldbuilding. These all work because they are compelling and moving stories above all, not climate science lectures dressed in a thin veil of narrative. Many other scriptwriters, novelists, social media creators, musicians and artists must add to this list.

I passionately believe that climate solutions are the most important story of this century.

When I return to that classroom over the coming years and ask the same two questions, the first answers will remain frightening. But when I ask what we can do about it, I hope every hand will shoot up, because we'll have filled kids' imaginations with enough possibilities that they can start inventing answers we haven't thought of yet. That will be a good day.

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https://time.com/article/2026/09/21/we-have-a-climate-imagination-problem/

Ideas | World

Philanthropy Must Build the Architecture of Hope

Nita M. Ambani is an Indian businesswoman, philanthropist and the chairperson of the Reliance Foundation.

Children play at a polling station at a school in Chennai, India, on April 23, 2026.R.Satish BABU-AFP-Getty Images

Nita M. Ambani is an Indian businesswoman, philanthropist and the chairperson of the Reliance Foundation.

I grew up in a middle class family in Mumbai, where my parents taught us the importance of giving back. Our success, they insisted, was meaningful only if it helped others rise. As a girl, I spent most Sundays accompanying my father as he distributed food to those in need. As a young teacher at an elementary school, I learned that the greatest gift a teacher offers is not knowledge itself but the confidence and capabilities it awakens in a child. And, as a mother, I experienced most profoundly that there is no greater joy than nurturing another life.

Mahatma Gandhi taught us that service to others is among life's highest forms of fulfilment. His ideas have shaped me and my ideas of philanthropy profoundly: *sarvodaya*, his vision of the

welfare of all, and, *antyodaya*, his insistence on the uplift of society's most marginalized.

But the highest purpose of philanthropy is to make itself obsolete. To do that, we must turn acts of care and generosity into lasting change by building institutions. Societies shape the future through the institutions they build: universities, hospitals, museums, scientific laboratories, and schools. Every generation has a responsibility to pass on stronger institutions to the next.

Our world is awash in plenty. Yet roughly between two to three billion people, especially in the Global South, remain deprived of nutritious food, adequate housing, clean water and sanitation, quality education and healthcare, secure livelihoods, and protection from environmental hazards. The primary responsibility for meeting these needs rests with governments, multilateral institutions, and businesses. But social transformation also requires philanthropic institutions capable of combining excellence with compassion, innovation with integrity, and purpose with performance.

Across India, I have encountered incredibly talented and dedicated doctors and nurses; teachers and artists; farmers, athletes, and volunteers. Extraordinary things happen when these talented and dedicated people find opportunity and support.

This belief guides my work as chair of India's Reliance Foundation, on every institution we have built—from excellent schools to a global university still taking shape; from high quality, affordable and accessible healthcare to a cultural center that showcases arts and artists from the world's great cities and India's remotest towns and villages; from an initiative that offers dignity and opportunity to millions of India's skilled craftspeople to an organization dedicated to protecting and caring for animals.

The most remarkable people I have met rarely ask for aid. What they seek is a chance: a chance to learn, to create, and to contribute. When society provides such opportunities reliably and at scale, lives are transformed. Institutions make this possible. They do more than solving the problems of our today; they prepare humanity for the possibilities of our tomorrow.

But building institutions demands patience. Institutions are gifts to those who inherit them; in time, they might create things their founders never imagined. I often think about the world our children, and their children, will inherit. I hope it will be healthier, kinder, more harmonious, more creative, and more compassionate. I hope it will be a world where every child has the freedom to dream without limits and the means to pursue those dreams with confidence.

The Sanskrit phrase *Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam* teaches us that the world is one family. I believe that institution-building is one of the purest expressions of this philosophy: it enlarges the circle of care to embrace humanity as a whole. And since all nations, communities, and cultures are branches of a single tree, we share a responsibility to tend it together.

Philanthropic institutions should forge bonds of mutual learning, exchange, and collaboration; partnerships help multiply the impact of philanthropy. Ultimately, philanthropy is not measured by the wealth we give away but by the futures we make possible, by the dreams that become reality because someone built something lasting. Time may dim the memory of who builds institutions, but the institutions themselves must shine on.

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https://time.com/article/2026/09/24/philanthropy-institutions-india-gandhi-ambani/

Ideas | Culture

How to Read the Room

Pamela Meyer is the author of How to Read the Room: The Art and Science of Social Observation.

topform84—Getty Images

Pamela Meyer is the author of How to Read the Room: The Art and Science of Social Observation.

Every room has a parallel conversation running underneath what appears on the surface. It’s a pulse, a vibe, a temperature. This undercurrent of unspoken behavior delivers data instantly, but only if you can decipher it.

Neuroscientists, psychologists, anthropologists, and linguists have studied subtle behaviors for years in a quest to unravel the mystery of how humans create meaning together. I’ve spent the last decade training others how to spot invisible signals, detect who holds power, identify which relationship will influence a decision, spot who has already made up their mind, and decipher who is lying.

These are the very skills you need to read the room—and they are all learnable. Here are four science-based approaches to improve your ability to do this:

Declutter your mind to get an accurate read

Your mood influences your judgment, and cognitive load distorts what you see. Happy people tend to predict positive outcomes and underestimate negative risks. Stressed minds can find hostility in neutral interactions, according to research by Australian psychologist Joseph Forgas. Landmark work by J.A. Easterbrook showed that emotion and strain reduce the range of cues we can take in and process.

Overload your mind, and you will misread the room. Heightened cognitive load, the baggage you carry into a meeting or conversation, distorts what you see. When your mind is cluttered with thoughts of a fight with your spouse or an unfinished project, you stop observing what's happening and start reading others through the prism of your own stress. In this mindset, a flat "thanks" can become a slight, and a colleague's distraction can feel like contempt.

When a room feels like it's turning against you, the first question worth asking is whether the room changed or your bandwidth did.

Manage what you transmit

Every gathering has a vibe. While that may sound like astrology, science tells us it's brain circuitry, and that we probably catch each other's moods far more often than we think.

Yale neuroscientists led by Joy Hirsch paired strangers face-to-face and used brain imaging to track what transferred when one person watched emotionally charged videos while the other person watched only the video-watcher. The second person began to

mirror the video-watcher's emotional state, even though they never saw the videos themself.

A 2023 study in *Communications Biology* timed the process: strangers watching television together synchronized their emotional responses within 850 milliseconds. The synchronization ran strongest during positive moments, suggesting joy travels freely while we keep our darker feelings hidden.

The emotional state you bring into a room can also shape how everyone else behaves before anyone has consciously registered that you're anxious or angry. An anxious person can make people rush or interrupt others more frequently. A contemptuous person can license cruelty and make dismissive jokes or harsh judgment feel acceptable. A calm person can reduce the temperature long enough for rational thought to return.

The message? Manage your own state of mind before you attempt to manage anyone else's.

Take note of who is missing in the room

A group's intelligence is not the sum of its IQs. Research by Carnegie Mellon Professor Anita Williams Woolley into the collective intelligence of teams found that group performance had less to do with average or maximum individual IQ than with collaboration. She found that strong groups have good communication skills, open minds, and an equal flow of ideas among participants. A room where one person dominates may feel decisive, but it may be losing intelligence in real time.

Watch who grabs attention and who recedes into the background. Who gets interrupted? Who is allowed to finish? Who tried to get into the conversation and then gave up? The smartest thing to do, for the group, is to allow everyone to speak and to be heard.

Read body language like a pro

Amateur room readers imbue simple gestures with definitive meaning: crossed arms signal defensiveness, eye contact suggests honesty. The pros observe changes from baseline and look for clusters of behavior that point in the same direction.

Science tells us how badly shortcuts deceive us. For example, many people believe that liars avoid eye contact. Researchers at an international airport asked 338 passengers from 81 countries to tell the truth or lie about their travel plans on camera. The liars held eye contact longer—deliberately, a beat past comfortable. Meanwhile, honest people, nervous under questioning, glanced away and looked guilty.

Fidgeting is also meaningless as a single gesture. Let's say someone taps their foot in a meeting or plays with their pen nervously. Maybe that's their norm. The behavior only becomes a signal when their pattern shifts. The savvy room reader asks what triggered the shift from baseline and watches for a cluster of behaviors. Did a particular question cause them to shift their posture, stop their normal foot-tapping, and freeze their blink-rate? That's worth noting.

The question is never, "What does this gesture mean?" The better question is, "What does this gesture mean here, from this person, under these conditions?"

Room reading is a powerful skill that's part social observation and part emotional intelligence.

As you start to see people and interactions more clearly, you'll alter your own behavior accordingly. And when you do, many more doors will open because you won't be guessing what the moment requires.

https://time.com/article/2026/09/07/how-to-read-the-room/

Politics

- **Iran War Has Cost U.S. Nearly $40 Billion and Fueled Inflation, CBO Finds**
  The report from the nonpartisan Congressional Budget Office estimates the war will cost the country another $2 billion to $3 billion each month it continues.

Politics | Iran

Iran War Has Cost U.S. Nearly $40 Billion and Fueled Inflation, CBO Finds

President Donald Trump and Secretary of Defense Pete Hegseth at a Cabinet meeting at Camp David in Maryland, on July 31, 2026Aaron Schwartz—AFP via Getty Images

The war with Iran has cost the U.S. government around $38 billion and contributed to growing inflation, according to a new analysis by the Congressional Budget Office, the nonpartisan agency that provides economic and budget estimates to Congress.

The estimate, which covers the war's direct costs through Aug. 1, is in line with the Pentagon's most recent public accounting from July, when Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth told Congress that the war had cost $37.5 billion. A later report from the Defense Department's inspector general determined that conflict cost an estimated $33.4 billion between February 28 and June 30.

But the new CBO analysis finds that the price of the war is continuing to rise, estimating that the government will spend another $2 billion to $3 billion each month the conflict continues. It also notes that the war has significantly depleted U.S. munitions,

including air-defense interceptors, potentially reducing the military’s capacity to respond to another major conflict.

Taken together, the reports are a mixed bag for an Administration that has faced mounting questions over the consequences of a war President Donald Trump initially said would be over in a few weeks. Nearly $40 billion is a substantial sum, Democrats say, particularly at a time when the federal government is carrying more than $40 trillion in gross debt and most Americans consider affordability their top issue heading in the midterms. However, the estimate is considerably lower than some early projections of what the conflict could cost, giving the Administration an argument that the direct military price of the war has so far been more limited than some critics had feared.

The bulk of the spending—$21.7 billion—comes from replacing munitions expenditures, the CBO found, including $13.1 billion for missile defense interceptors and $7.3 billion for land-attack cruise missiles. Other costs include repairing or replacing equipment, increased flying hours for air operations and transportation, and increased fuel costs. However, it does not factor in the cost of damage to U.S. bases and facilities in the Middle East.

The separate report from the Defense Department's inspector general, released a day before the CBO’s, estimated the cost of repairing "physical damage from Iranian strikes" to U.S. diplomatic facilities in Iraq, Kuwait, Saudi Arabia, and the UAE at approximately $184 million. It also determined that throughout Operation Epic Fury the U.S. military has spent $22.3 billion on munitions and has lost around $3.7 billion in aircraft and equipment, including four destroyed F-15 fighter jets, seven KC-135 tanker aircraft, a dozen damaged or destroyed KC-135 refueling aircraft, and the loss of up to 30 MQ-9 Reaper drones.

The CBO estimates that replenishing the stockpiles depleted by the war could take five years or longer, suggesting the true cost of the

conflict could not be known until the Pentagon spends money to rebuild inventories and restore capabilities that existed before the war. Top Administration officials have repeatedly denied claims of U.S. munitions shortages ahead of the two reports, though the Defense Department urged the defense industry to increase weapons manufacturing last month.

The CBO's accounting gives members of Congress an independent assessment against which to judge the Trump Administration's requests to continue funding its military campaign in Iran. As Congress's nonpartisan fiscal scorekeeper, the CBO's findings frequently become the benchmark lawmakers use to debate the consequences of tax and spending decisions. However, the CBO report notes that its own estimates "are subject to considerable uncertainty" because it relied on government databases and public reports as the Defense Department did not respond to the CBO's requests for information.

Democrats are using the findings to argue that the money could have been better spent easing the cost of living. "Donald Trump and Republicans have spent years telling Americans that we cannot afford to help families here at home, but apparently they can find tens of billions of dollars, and potentially much more, for a reckless war that is leaving Americans to pay the price," Rep. Brendan Boyle, the ranking member of the House Budget Committee, said in a statement. In March, Boyle asked the agency to examine the costs of military operations and the conflict's effects on prices at home.

Democrats were expecting the cost estimate to be higher than the CBO reached in its report, in part because they believed it would account for the cost of borrowing to finance the war. The $40 billion figure does not include debt service, or additional interest the government could pay over time.

As a result, the CBO estimate is not a final accounting. Much of the information needed to assess the military's expenditures remains classified or undisclosed, and the eventual bill will also depend on decisions still ahead about troop deployments, replenishing weapons, and rebuilding damaged American bases.

Earlier this summer, the White House requested an additional $67.1 billion for the Pentagon, while House Republicans later advanced a spending framework containing roughly $73 billion in additional funding for defense and intelligence as Democrats pushed back, saying that they lack a clear picture of the war's duration and ultimate requirements.

Outside Washington, the costs are less abstract. The national average price of regular gasoline reached $4.33 a gallon on Tuesday, up from $4.01 a month earlier. Diesel surpassed $6 a gallon, increasing the expense of moving goods across the country. An Energy Department forecast released last Wednesday projected that gasoline would remain near $4 for the rest of the year.

The CBO expects the war to add roughly 0.5 percentage points to inflation in the price index for personal consumption expenditures in the first quarter of 2027, driven largely by higher energy prices resulting from supply disruptions in the Strait of Hormuz and the Red Sea.

Inflation reached an annual rate of 3.4% in August, according to figures released Friday, compared with 2.4% in February.

The pace of the war has ebbed and flowed in recent months, with sporadic bursts of fighting and attacks across the region. Shipping through the Strait of Hormuz remains disrupted, renewed attacks have threatened commercial vessels, and Houthi strikes on Saudi energy infrastructure have complicated efforts to move oil through alternative routes. The uncertainty has helped push oil prices back above $100 a barrel.

Trump has more recently asked Americans to accept higher prices as the cost of preventing Iran from acquiring a nuclear weapon. His assurances about the duration of that sacrifice, however, have changed. In March, he described the war as a “short-term excursion” that would end “soon.” Last week, speaking at a Republican convention in Dallas, he said the war would end “immediately after” the midterm elections.

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https://time.com/article/2026/09/15/iran-war-cost-inflation-cbo-report/

TIME100

- **TIME100 Next 2026: The World's Most Influential Rising Stars**
  Introducing the 2026 TIME100 Next: people from around the world who are shaping the future and defining the next generation of leadership.

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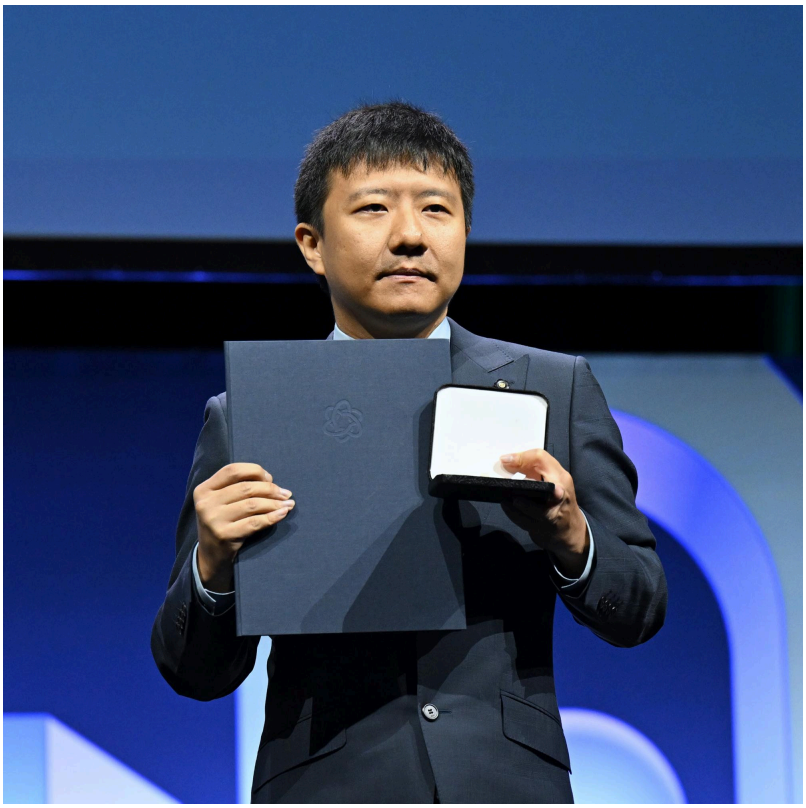

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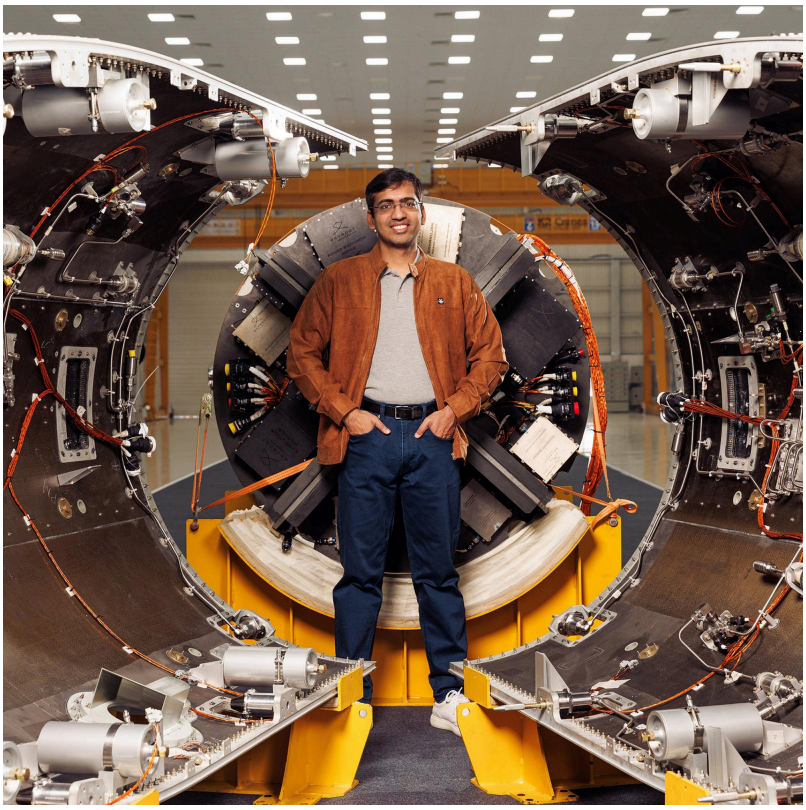

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U.S.

- **Exclusive: The Admiral Who Must Prevent War With China**
  U.S Pacific Commander Samuel Paparo’s force covers more than half the earth’s surface. His goal? Winning without fighting.
- **Crisis at the Kennedy Center: Why Its Main Building Is Going Dark for Two Years**
  The decision comes amid safety concerns, financial turmoil, and a legal fight over efforts to put President Donald Trump’s name on the building.
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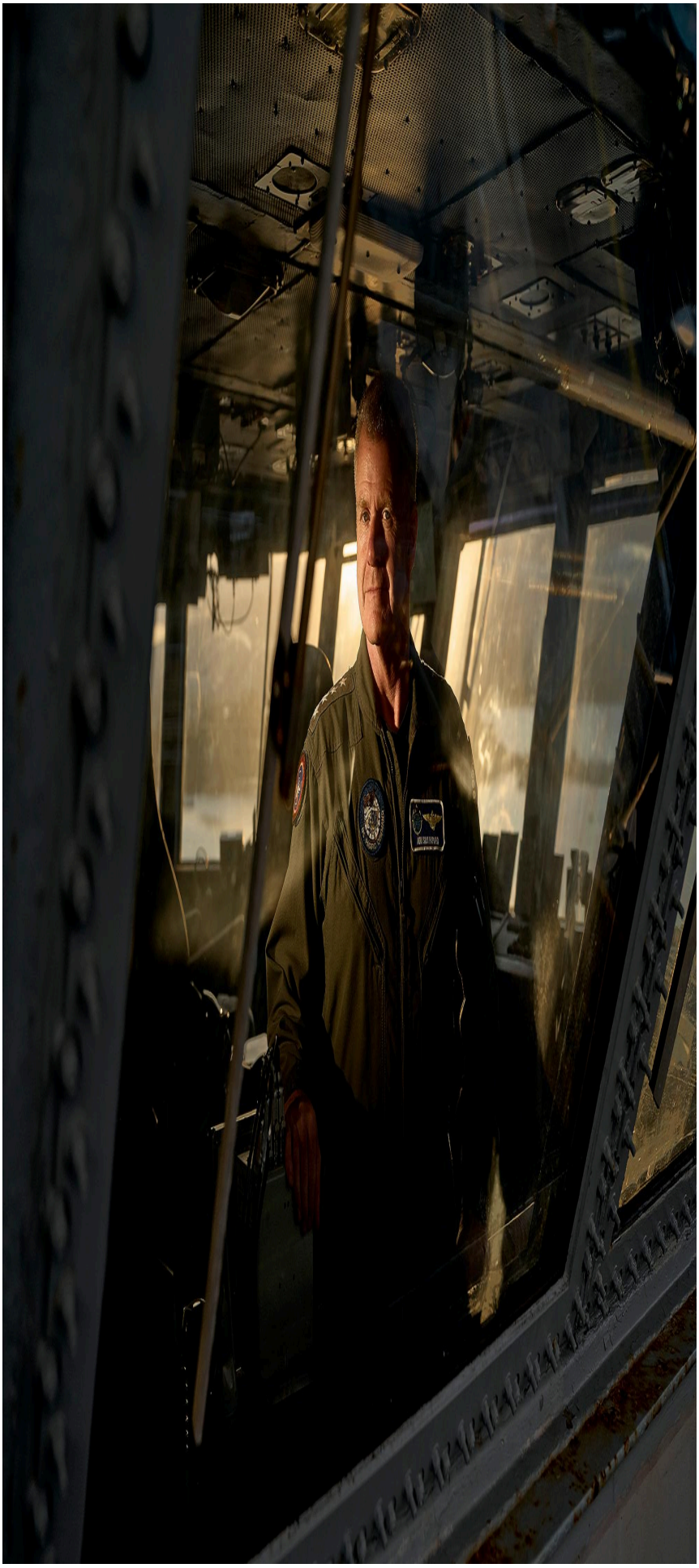

U.S. | China

Exclusive: The Admiral Who Must Prevent War With China

Samuel Paparo aboard the USS Theodore Roosevelt at Pearl Harbor on July 29, 2026.Photograph by Philip Cheung for TIME

Story

by

Richard Hall

Samuel Paparo aboard the USS Theodore Roosevelt at Pearl Harbor on July 29, 2026. Photograph by Philip Cheung for TIME

In the summer of 1986, when he was a college student in Pennsylvania, Samuel Paparo took his future wife Maureen to watch Top Gun.

Many young Americans emerged from theaters across the country with a new hero: the brash, daring, risk-taking Maverick, played by Tom Cruise, who became an avatar of American power at the twilight of the Cold War. But Paparo took away a different lesson.

“The hero of the movie is supposed to be Maverick, but the hero of the movie is actually Iceman,” Paparo tells TIME, referring to the main character’s rival at the elite Navy pilot training school. “Maverick’s got all the personal charisma, but Iceman is fastidious, quiet. He’s the hard-working guy that does the right thing, that doesn’t do flashy, dangerous stuff for its own sake.”

Paparo had already passed the Navy’s entrance exams when he went into the theater that day, and joined the next year. His career would precisely mirror the fictional Iceman’s: He attended the Navy Fighter Weapons School, also known as TOPGUN; became a fighter pilot; then a four-star admiral; and eventually commanded the Pacific Fleet. But Paparo would go further, taking the helm of the U.S. Pacific Command, the nation’s oldest and largest geographic combatant command, which covers about half of the earth’s surface.

Few Americans will have heard of Admiral Paparo, and that suits him fine. “If I do my job right, history will never know my name,” he says in his office at the headquarters of the U.S. Pacific Command in Hawaii, on a hill overlooking Pearl Harbor, in late July. But his role places him at an inflection point, as American dominance in the Pacific faces its most serious challenge since World War II.

His command is designed to be the immovable object that blocks the unstoppable force of China’s expansionist ambitions in the

region. And those ambitions have been stated clearly: Beijing has vowed to bring Taiwan, the self-ruling island that has been politically separate from the mainland since China's civil war ended in 1949, under its control—by force if necessary. China's President Xi Jinping has described unification as "a historical inevitability."

Paparo's job, in its simplest terms, is the projection of American power. His most important mission is to deter a Chinese invasion of Taiwan, an event that would challenge the very foundations of a global system underpinned by American hegemony. That the outlines of this mission stay the same regardless of which party or President is in the White House speaks to the importance of his role. The force Paparo builds and the plans he puts in place last for decades, and could determine to whom the next century belongs.

Photograph by Philip Cheung for TIME

The public face of American military power is, of course, the Commander in Chief. The public voice emanates from the Oval Office and the podium in the White House press briefing room. But behind that power sits commanders like Paparo, overseeing the often hidden and awesome infrastructure that backs up that public face and voice—his command oversees some 400,000 military and civilian personnel, a Pacific Fleet of some 200 ships, including five aircraft carrier strike groups, and more than 1,000 aircraft. He marshals that power in distant oceans, islands, and military bases that most Americans will never see or even think about.

With President Donald Trump set to meet Thursday with China's Xi for their third face-to-face summit since he returned to office,

the cameras are trained on the White House; reporters will parse each utterance by the two leaders to divine whether the two powers are heading toward cooperation or conflict. It is Paparo's job to ensure that whatever happens when the leaders talk, U.S. power remains pre-eminent—and that if somehow in the future conflict breaks out, it comes out on top. He must hold to that approach even as wars elsewhere consume the munitions and resources he may need, and upheaval at the Pentagon raises the stakes of pushing back.

"I'm almost quoting Sun Tzu when I say winning without fighting is the acme of skill," he says, referencing the Chinese military strategist who wrote *The Art of War.* "Mission success for me is not to fight and win a war; it's to provide a deterrent capability so that we never go to war in the first place."

Paparo, 61, speaks deliberately and in a low voice, smiling often. But when conversation turns serious, so does his expression—his brows become furrowed, and he stares into the middle distance to summon his words. "We don't seek to become great wartime leaders," he says. "We seek to be great peacetime deterrers."

Taiwanese troops set anti-tank barriers on Tamkang Bridge during drills on Aug. 6, 2026.Daniel Ceng—Anadolu/Getty Images

What if deterrence doesn't work? The U.S. emerged from World War II with its dominance of the Pacific unquestioned, but that may now be changing. Over the past few decades, as China has transformed into the world's second largest economy, it has been engaged in a historic military buildup. China's defense spending has increased 13-fold over the past three decades, and it now spends more on defense than the next 22 Indo-Pacific countries combined, according to the Center for Strategic and International Studies (CSIS), a bipartisan Washington, D.C.–based think tank. It has made rapid technological advances in artificial intelligence and fielded several generations of fighter jets. Its navy has grown from a coastal force into something capable of projecting global power, and by hull count it is now the largest in the world.

Brian Hart, deputy director of the China Power Project at CSIS, describes it as a "comprehensive, across-the-board modernization effort," one that has changed the calculus for every power in the Pacific. The People's Liberation Army, he tells TIME, has "significantly transformed the balance of power."

Paparo need only look out his office window at the turquoise waters of Pearl Harbor to be reminded of the last time U.S. supremacy in the Pacific was truly tested. He describes China's buildup as "historic" and "an exponential increase in military power, and more specifically, in power projection capability."

"Twenty-five years ago the People's Liberation Army Navy was about 37 warships, and today it's 12 times that," he says. "Just in the last 18 months they've delivered two cruisers, eight destroyers, eight frigates, an aircraft carrier, 11 submarines, four amphibious ships, and four long-range combat logistics ships." He is particularly concerned by China's advances in space and missile development and the rapid expansion of its nuclear arsenal. "They're moving toward world reach," he says.

For all of its global ambitions, much of China's military development has been pursued with one target in mind. U.S. intelligence assesses that China's Xi has ordered his military to be capable of seizing Taiwan by force by 2027, the centenary of the People's Liberation Army. The intelligence community's annual threat assessment, released in March, suggests no invasion is currently planned for next year, but by then, the pieces Xi needs to do so will likely be in place.

If there appears to be a path to capturing Taiwan without using force, Xi insists he would prefer to take it. Presidential elections in Taiwan in January 2028 may provide some clarity in that regard: China's old rival, the Kuomintang, is increasingly amenable to negotiations with Beijing. If the political party wins in 2028, the likelihood of an invasion may decrease. If Taiwan's President Lai Ching-te, a fierce opponent of China's sovereignty claims, wins reelection, Hart says, "Beijing could significantly ramp up pressure on Taiwan."

Paparo's job is to convince Xi that the costs of military action will be too much to bear, regardless of what is happening politically on the island. By act of Congress, the U.S. is obliged to sell Taiwan the weapons it needs for its own defense; while it does not require the U.S. to defend the island directly, the commitment could go further to include direct conflict with China. He describes his mission as a delicate balancing act between ensuring that his counterparts know American capabilities well enough to understand the risks of engaging, and protecting its necessary secrets and strategy. "It's demonstrating credible combat power, demonstrating capability and will, but keeping the crown jewels of the nation that are going to deliver combat success opaque to your counterparts, so that they can't build a counter for it," he says.

Paparo describes the strategy as deterrence by denial. "It's a way of expressing that we're not seeking the overthrow of the Communist Party," he says. "It's just that you should know that where

America’s direct vital interests are involved, there’s a high probability of denying your aggression.”

This theory of deterrence operates on a grand, geopolitical scale, and in much smaller interactions. Paparo recounts a confrontation with a Chinese counterpart over what he describes as an “unsafe” encounter in June 2023 during a transit of the Taiwan Strait in which a Chinese Luyang destroyer cut across the bow of an American ship.

In the ensuing back-and-forth, Paparo told his counterpart that he had been in command at the watch center for the engagement and had video showing that their version of events was not true. He offered to share it, then let the matter rest.

“I’m not going to impugn his own character in it. He’s representing his country. He’s in uniform, and you know, if we do have a fight, him and I might have to shake hands at the end and agree to go to our separate sides,” he says.

In that moment, Paparo chose a diplomatic approach. He does, however, have a more direct plan to deter a Chinese attack on Taiwan. It is based on a term he uses to describe the environment Chinese forces would walk into if they took military action: “Hellscape.”

The strategy has been partly inspired by Ukraine’s defense against Russian invasion, and its ability to halt Moscow’s advances by turning the front lines of that conflict into a no-man’s-land patrolled by killer drones. Paparo would aim to saturate the Taiwan Strait with cheap, mass-produced precision drones, along with more conventional high-tech missile power, to deny China the ability to land an amphibious assault, or at least significantly delay it.

“We’ve seen that assault warfare, whether that is an amphibious assault, an airborne assault, has become a much more costly human endeavor,” he says. “In the ways that Ukraine is about a 600-mile-by-30-mile hellscape of drone warfare, I seek to put those principles at work to deter an armed invasion.”

He continues: “Putting 21st century technological change to work for the United States of America is what that’s about. We need not gain air or maritime superiority of a space; we need only deny its use to aggressors.”

Direct American involvement in a conflict over Taiwan is by no means assured. Paparo is tasked with building a force to confront China, but the President will decide how to respond. “The highest ideals of American civil-military relations are such that policy is king,” he says.

Who would win that conflict is something that is fiercely debated. A 2023 CSIS war game found that the U.S. and its allies defeated a Chinese amphibious invasion of Taiwan in most scenarios, but the costs to the U.S. were substantial: two aircraft carriers, dozens of ships, and hundreds of aircraft, the heaviest American losses since World War II. Those war games were run before the war in Iran depleted U.S. missile stocks.

“I am confident in our ability to prevail,” Paparo says. “What I am working toward is the margin by which we do, and that margin expresses itself in lives, capability, money, and time. I want to drive that bill down to zero.”

Sailors assigned to Flag Detail practice folding an American flag aboard the USS Theodore Roosevelt.Photograph by Philip Cheung for TIME

An enormous map of the Indo-Pacific theater lines the wall of Paparo's office. His desk overlooks a large room adorned with historical Pacific artifacts and gifts given to the admiral and his predecessors: a five-star flag that belonged to General Douglas MacArthur; a barometer gifted to Admiral Harry Harris Jr., who led the command from 2015 to 2018, by China's Ministry of National Defense. Closer to his desk is a large computer screen showing the positions of every vessel under his command. As he toggles through the ships on the screen to demonstrate the scale of his fleet, he pauses somewhere near the Indian Ocean to press home a point: His command is not merely preparing for war; it is fighting one. "The Iranian frigate was sunk by us," he says. He is referring to an incident in March, when the U.S.S. *Charlotte* submarine torpedoed and sank the Iranian navy frigate IRIS *Dena* in the Indian Ocean as it was returning to Iran from India, where it had taken part in an international exercise. More than 100 Iranian sailors were killed. Paparo's forces have also helped enforce a blockade of Iran's coastline and support logistics for the war.

That the U.S. Pacific Command is fighting one war on one side of the world while preparing for another 6,000 miles away in the Taiwan Strait is a measure of its scale. As he stands in front of his map, Paparo sweeps his arm down the Western seaboard, along the coast to Southern California, and across the central Pacific, pointing out an array of U.S. territories and possessions. These places may seem like distant lands to many Americans. To Paparo, they are as much a part of the U.S. as New York or California. To see the Pacific in this way is to understand the meaning behind this projection of power: it's not just for the protection of an important strategic partner in Taiwan; it is for the protection of the U.S. itself. "There's no more Pacific a country in the world than the United States of America," he says.

It's not just about Taiwan and China, either. The North Koreans, he says, "are seeking a nuclear deterrent" and want to present the world with a "fait accompli." The Russians "have increased their air, missile, and maritime capabilities."

Much of the job is managing friends rather than enemies. The Pentagon has called on Paparo to mediate between allies at odds with one another, and he says there is nothing new in that. Those military-to-military relationships, he adds, "tend to be an anchor that attenuates the ups and downs of policy disagreements among political leaders ... but it always respects the national policy of our civilian leadership."

Few conflicts in the world today do not brush up against the Indo-Pacific theater or impact it in some way. The Iran war and U.S. support for Ukraine have placed severe strain on the resources available to all commands, causing a depletion in the stockpiles for missile defense like the Patriot and THAAD systems, and in long-range ground attack missiles, according to the Pentagon and CSIS estimates.

In May, a planned $14 billion arms package for Taiwan was put under review in part to preserve munitions for the Iran war. Experts have warned it may take years to replenish those stocks, a timeline that could affect the calculus of China and Russia.

Those shortages are no secret, but it's a perilous time to be out of step with the White House and the Pentagon. At least 20 top military leaders, including generals and admirals, have been fired or left their positions since Pete Hegseth became Secretary of Defense at the start of the second Trump Administration. The turmoil culminated in the late August resignation of Army Secretary Dan Driscoll, who reportedly left his role after clashing with Hegseth over the firings of senior generals and the Secretary's alleged stymieing of Army modernization efforts in the midst of a U.S. war against Iran.

Hegseth has characterized those departures as part of a campaign to undo what he saw as the promotion of "woke" leadership. In a speech in September 2025 in Quantico, Va., to the military's generals and admirals, all of whom were required to attend, Hegseth criticized the promotion of leaders for what he described as "the wrong reasons, based on their race, based on gender quotas, based on historic so-called firsts." Paparo was visible in the front row of that gathering, his expression giving nothing away.

Paparo, front row, at a gathering of military leaders in Quantico, Va., on Sept. 30, 2025.Doug Mills —The New York Times/Redux

He has been careful in his public remarks about the impact the war in Iran has had on the readiness of his command. When questioned in the Senate about how prolonged conflict could impinge on his mission, Paparo conceded only that "there are finite limits to the magazine, and I have all the faith in the world that they're being employed judiciously."

In private, he appears to have been more candid. Paparo's name emerged recently in a Washington *Post* report on a classified assessment, along with other combatant commanders, in which he is said to have objected to the continued use of an aircraft carrier strike group and destroyers for the war in Iran. He was also named in a New York *Times* report as one of several "private interlocutors" who had been offering "unvarnished" views of the Iran war to Vice President JD Vance. Vance's team declined to comment on the report.

Ward Carroll, a Navy veteran who flew in F-14s and a friend of Paparo's for many years, says the admiral's circumspection is part of his character. "He doesn't want headlines," he says. "He's not out there like some other folks have been, saying Epic Fury was a huge mistake. He may say it in private ... but he's certainly not going to say it to the media or allow it to be leaked." Paparo excels, Carroll says, by choosing not to "wade into the food fight that is modern-day media and politics at all." A spokesperson for Pacific Command declined to comment on Paparo's private conversations about the Iran war.

When TIME asks Paparo about the potential impact of Ukraine and Iran, he is again cautious, pivoting to the lessons the U.S. is learning from both: namely the rapid deployment of drones in Ukraine and of AI-enabled operations in Iran, which were used to select and recommend targets for the U.S. military.

“The nature of an operation in the Pacific would be to counter an amphibious invasion. Well, we’ve just not used a lot of anti-ship weapons—we still maintain robust inventories of those,” he says. “And so, while I’m not going to whistle past the problem of the expenditure of munitions, it is our job to charge into the learning, and for us to get better.”

Paparo speaks to sailors aboard the USS Theodore Roosevelt at Pearl Harbor.Photograph by Philip Cheung for TIME

If there is a permanence to America’s projection of power in the Pacific, it can also be found in Paparo’s own family. His father Samuel Paparo Sr., who died in February, served four years in the Marine Corps before becoming a shipworker at the Philadelphia Naval Shipyard. There he helped refit the aircraft carrier U.S.S. *Kitty Hawk* and repair the U.S.S. *John F. Kennedy.* The younger Paparo would later fly from both. “He was really proud of that,” he says of his father. His grandfather was a Seabee, serving in one of the Navy’s construction battalions across the Pacific during World War II, in Bora Bora, Guam, and other islands. He died when Paparo was 13, but he left behind an old wooden scrapbook he had built with pictures from the war and all the places he had been. A young Paparo would pick it up from time to time and leaf through

it. “I don’t think he imagined his grandson to be here in command,” he says.

His mother washed hair in a South Philadelphia barbershop and later worked a makeup counter in a department store. “Neither my father nor his father finished high school. In fact, nobody in my family before me had ever had a university education,” he says. He would later attend Villanova, the Catholic college also attended by the first American Pontiff, Pope Leo XIV. “We make Popes and admirals,” he says of his alma mater.

He joined TOPGUN, whose exacting culture left a lasting impression. “What the school confers is attention to detail, dedication to execution, dedication to getting better, and being introspective and running to your own problems, of seeking the perfect flight that you’ll never get,” he adds. He flew F-14, F-15, and F/A-18 jets, and clocked more than 6,000 flight hours and 1,100 carrier landings. He says he initially aimed to serve as long as his father. “Serving for four years was intentional, and serving for 40 was a blessing,” he adds.

Paparo’s time leading the Pacific Command is historic not just for the opponent he faces, but also because it coincides with a rapid and dramatic change in the nature of warfare. On one wall of his office hangs a reprint of a TIME cover from May 18, 1942, depicting Admiral Chester Nimitz, the naval commander who led the U.S. to victory over Japan at sea in the Pacific war. Nimitz took command of the Pacific Fleet in December 1941, also at a time of great technological change.

After Pearl Harbor, and under Nimitz’s watch, the battleship would be eclipsed by the aircraft carrier. Amphibious warfare would be revolutionized and directed under a single commander. And then there was the kamikaze—organized suicide attacks by aircraft flown by Japanese pilots—and their foreshadowing of the questions posed by the advancement of unmanned aerial drones in

warfare today. “He adapted to change, including the unknown,” Paparo says of Nimitz. “That’s the greatest leadership model I can think of.”

Paparo hopes that he never has to fight the war he has spent so long preparing for, that his plans go untested and passed on to the next commander. In the meantime, he will continue with the quiet work. “Mine is not a heroic story,” he says. “Heroism is service that happens at the unforgiving hour. The best service prevents the unforgiving hour.”

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https://time.com/article/2026/09/24/admiral-paparo-war-china-taiwan/

U.S.

Crisis at the Kennedy Center: Why Its Main Building Is Going Dark for Two Years

A tarp covers the facade of the Kennedy Center in Washington, D.C., on Aug. 28, 2026.Daniel Heuer —Bloomberg/Getty Images

The Kennedy Center Board of Trustees on Tuesday voted to immediately close the lauded arts institution's main building. President Donald Trump, who is its Chairman, announced the decision on Truth Social.

Hours before the vote, a district court ruled against the Board's latest effort to add Trump's name back to the building—this time, in recognition of his purported role in the planned renovations. The closure decision also came one day after leadership claimed that the cultural center was on the brink of bankruptcy.

The Board's closure vote was informed, in part, by a 57-page packet provided Monday as preparatory material for their meeting. It claimed that keeping the main building open endangered both visitors and staff of the institution, according to the *Washington Post*.

Read More: *All the Things Trump Has Put His Name and Face on as President*

The packet included a two-page memorandum from Executive Director Matt Floca, who was installed by Trump in March. According to the *Post*, the letter points to an incident on Sept. 4 wherein a chunk of the ceiling in the grand foyer fell after heavy rains, spreading debris in front of the Concert Hall.

A copy of the resolution to close the building was also filed in court Monday as part of ongoing litigation to keep Trump's name off the front portico. It said that the Virginia-based firm Delta Consulting Group performed an independent assessment in August and found that the Kennedy Center was in an escalating state of disrepair.

"Both Delta Consulting Group and the Center's own Executive Director consider the main building to be unsafe for continued occupancy, and anticipate further risk to the public and employees if the building is not immediately closed and renovations begun," the resolution said.

The claim has been disputed by Democratic Rep. Joyce Beatty of Ohio, an *ex officio* Kennedy Center Board member who first brought a lawsuit against Trump for his attempted rebrand in December 2025 and subsequently challenged multiple prior motions to close the Center. Beatty's lawyers argued that Delta Consulting Group had "expressly disclaimed providing any such opinion."

TIME has reached out to the Delta Consulting Group for comment.

Following the closure, Beatty's legal team issued a statement calling the closure "more of the same failure and abuse." They accused the Board of using the shutdown to obscure mismanagement under its current leadership and said they would continue the court fight.

A Kennedy Center spokesperson pointed TIME to a statement given by Roma Daravi, the Kennedy Center's Vice President of Public Relations, in the aftermath of the falling ceiling plaster incident. She called the incident "another example of the urgent need to close for renovation and revitalization" and said there is "no justification for further delays in restoring America's cultural center."

In light of the D.C. Circuits ruling on Tuesday, however, Trump threatened to prevent the planned renovations from proceeding until he received a favorable ruling regarding the addition of his name to the building.

In a Truth Social post he wrote that if the court's decision "is not overturned by the U.S. Supreme Court, the Reconstruction and the Renovation of The Kennedy Center will not take place."

The closure is just the latest episode in the Trump-related turmoil that has afflicted the storied arts center located on the banks of the Potomac River in Washington, D.C.

How Trump reshaped the Kennedy Center

After President Donald Trump returned to the White House, he promptly staged a takeover at what had formerly been a nonpartisan institution.

In February 2025, he dismissed all Board members appointed by former President Joe Biden and replaced them with his own appointees. The newly formed Board then unanimously named him its Chairman.

Deborah Rutter, who served as Kennedy Center President for over a decade, was also ousted.

Soon after, Trump dissolved the Center's Social Impact division. The move came amid broader Trump Administration efforts to roll back diversity initiatives at federally supported cultural institutions, including the Smithsonian, which closed its diversity office following his executive orders.

Trump also said he became "very involved" in choosing nominees for the 2025 Kennedy Center Honors, an annual award given to performing artists for their lifetime of contributions to American culture. Traditionally, they are selected by members of the Board with input from the public and past honorees.

"I turned down plenty. They were too woke. I had a couple of 'wokesters,'" Trump told reporters in August.

After Trump's takeover, some performers and art enthusiasts vowed to boycott the performances, and in June 2025, the *Washington Post* reported that subscriptions had already fallen 36% from the year prior and were down by about $1.6 million.

Kennedy Center leadership warns of bankruptcy

On Tuesday, the U.S. District Court for the District of Columbia struck down the Board's latest attempt to add the President's name to the front of the Kennedy Center.

It was their second such effort after their previous renaming effort was struck down in May, when Judge Christopher Cooper ruled that it violated a 1964 statute requiring congressional approval. Congress repurposed its planned National Culture Center in 1964 as a living memorial to President John F. Kennedy.

Cooper ordered the signage removed, and the lettering came down in June.

Amid that legal battle, the Department of Justice filed emergency stay arguments, warning that removing Trump's name would "impede the Center's fundraising efforts and contribute to the financial decline of the Center."

However, when the D.C. Circuit denied the stay on July 8, it said the defendants had provided no evidence of financial harm.

On Aug. 13, the Board passed a resolution to a new inscription to the building "to recognize and honor President Trump's current and future existential and unprecedented contributions to the survival of the Center." The plan involved adding new lettering to the marble facade, just below the building's name, in an area that has been blocked by scaffolding and tarp since Trump's name was removed. Trustees also determined that the plaza would be dedicated to Trump.

The Board argued that the proposed changes did not constitute an institutional name change and therefore complied with the earlier ruling.

But the court rejected both the renovation inscription and the plaza renaming, while declining to rule on the contingent endowment inscription.

"Defendants are hereby enjoined from inscribing 'renovated and restored by Donald J. Trump' on the main building or renaming the campus the 'President Donald J. Trump Plaza,'" the court order said. "Simply put, Defendants cannot install memorials for President Trump or anyone or anything else at the Kennedy Center without Congress's blessing."

The ruling addressed the Board's August plan, but another potential naming effort was already taking shape.

In response to the ruling, Beatty's co-counsel Norm Eisen posted a statement on X saying, "2 times the court has told Trump the same thing: You are not above the law. Legal sanity has once again prevailed over Trump's vanity. This is a victory for the memory of Pres. Kennedy & our nation."

On the day of the decision, the Board had been scheduled to consider yet another resolution saying that it would "undertake all legal means to effectuate one or more of the following." It listed 10 options for consideration, including "Renovation and endowment overseen by President Donald J. Trump and the Trump Kennedy Center Fund" and "A Legacy protected through the Generosity of President Donald J. Trump."

However, Joe LaFauci, the Vice President of Board Relations, informed the Board overnight Monday that, "[d]ue to the recently exacerbated structural emergencies," the Tuesday meeting "is now focused exclusively on the necessary closure of the Center," according to *ABC News*.

Whether the Board will reschedule a vote on the resolution, despite the latest court ruling, is to be determined. The resolution itself had painted an alarming picture for the institution in its justification for a new inscription.

That proposal also made explicit how closely the Board had linked the naming fight to the Center's financial future.

The Kennedy Center is "in a dire financial position" and could be weeks away from bankruptcy, it said. It went on to claim that the center cannot be saved without support from Trump—which may be contingent on public acknowledgement.

"The Board understands that without such appropriate recognition it is unlikely that President Trump will provide the fundamental

oversight of the renovation of the main building and lead the fiscal rescue of the Center," the resolution said.

The proposed Trump Kennedy Center Fund had not raised any money as of Sept. 15, according to NPR.

Charlotte Canning, a professor and theater historian at the University of Texas at Austin, believes that the claims were part of a bold if desperate strategy to force the courts to allow the inscription to go forward.

"I think it's an expression of Trump's continuing frustration that he can't sort of hold the Kennedy Center's reputation under his own, and therefore benefit," Canning tells TIME. "It's the Trump Administration saying: 'If you don't let us do what we want, we will declare bankruptcy.'"

Can the Kennedy Center afford a two-year closure?

The path to Tuesday's immediate closure decision has involved repeated attempts at intervention from both the court and the Board.

On March 16, after determining that vast renovations were needed, the Board voted to completely shutter the main building after the July 4 celebrations and proceed with planned renovations. A federal judge invalidated that decision in May; however, most scheduled programming was canceled and its stages have been largely silent this summer.

After considering full, partial, and phased closure options, the Board again approved a two-year closure on Aug. 13. While budgetary constraints were a factor in the decision, the Board was looking at a set of financial conditions entirely separate from the compromised operating budget.

Congress appropriated $256,657,000 in restricted funding to the Center in July 2025, with the condition that the funds must be used for “capital repair, restoration, maintenance backlog, and security structures” and are available through Sept. 30, 2029.

The two-year closure puts the Kennedy Center within that established timeline. Renovations were projected at approximately $257 million, matching the allocated taxpayer funding.

But even with that federal money in place, the scope and urgency of the proposed work remain contested.

Canning questions the two-year renovation plan, saying that while the almost-60-year-old building likely requires maintenance and renovations on a regular basis, current assessments of its condition seem like hyperbole—especially when it comes to matters of life and death.

Commerce Secretary Howard Lutnick, whose wife Allison serves on the Board, posted a video of the ceiling collapse Monday on X and wrote, “If a performance had been underway, patrons could have been killed.”

“It’s all a part of this bamboozling plan to create a dire situation and then swoop in as the savior,” Canning says.

In *Beatty v Trump*, Beatty’s attorneys argued that both of the board’s resolutions are an attempt to capitulate to the president, with one of them calling the resolutions a “hostage taking” of the Center.

“Pay up or the Kennedy Center closes, & the price is Trump’s name on the building,” Eisen wrote Monday on X, commenting on the information that had been given to the Board.

A Kennedy Center spokesperson, however, told TIME that adding “Trump’s name to the building attracted new donors and was

crucial to raising additional funds for the Center's renovation."

The Kennedy Center counts ticket sales among its significant revenue sources; in fiscal year 2024, the most recent year for which filing data is available, ticket sales and other operations-driven revenue accounted for over 34% of the Center's reported $306.88 million revenue. The *Washington Post* reported in October 2025, within nine months of Trump's takeover, that ticket sales for the three largest of nine performance spaces had fallen to their lowest level in years.

Trump wrote on Truth Social on Tuesday, "Remember, The Kennedy Center was losing Hundreds of Millions of Dollars when I took over. It was failing badly! It had nothing to do with me, I am only there to help."

A Kennedy Center spokesperson told TIME that assets and income were actually "up significantly" for fiscal year 2025. The institution is behind on filing its Form 990 for that fiscal year, and did not provide supplementary documentation to that effect. However, it reported a surplus of nearly $41 million in fiscal year 2024.

Philip Hackney, a law professor at the University of Pittsburgh and former counsel for the Internal Revenue Service, questioned the logic of warning about imminent bankruptcy while planning to continue some institutional activities during the closure.

"It makes no sense at all," he says. "If a nonprofit is planning to go bankrupt—and I don't know why a memorial to a former president that has a line from Congress would propose such a thing—but if you're planning to go bankrupt, you really shut down all activities."

Cooper separately rejected the government's claims about the potential financial harm of keeping Trump's name off the Center.

He wrote in his ruling on Tuesday that the government offered “no proof that current or future donations hinge on President Trump’s name being on the building” and “no competent evidence that removing the Trump name would prevent the Center from fulfilling its artistic mission, as it has done for the last sixty years.”

There is also evidence that Trump’s involvement may have caused some additional harm. After announcing the renaming earlier this year, the prestigious cultural center faced multiple performance cancellations—which Canning says has prevented the institution from making as much money as it could have before the planned closure.

“Large-scale institutions like this book well over a year out. So it means that starting at the beginning of 2025, when they would have been booking for now and the future, they weren't,” she says. “In fact, what they were doing instead was having to deal with cancellations.”

Canning says the Center’s financial problems are unsurprising after a year of cancellations, diminished bookings, and litigation.

“Any claims that the Kennedy Center is in financial trouble, I believe,” she says, “but they're all problems of their own manufacturing.”

What comes next for the embattled Kennedy Center

Any future efforts to add Trump’s name to the Kennedy Center, in whatever form they may take, will almost certainly be challenged in court.

Even as that legal fight continues, however, the closure will not halt all of the Kennedy Center’s activities.

While the cultural center's main building—which includes the Concert Hall, the Opera House, and the Eisenhower Theater—is closed, certain programming elements will continue at REACH, an indoor and outdoor campus expansion that opened in 2019.

The center also said that it will still be "maintaining educational outreach to the community" and that it will continue presenting the Kennedy Center Honors and awarding the Mark Twain Prize for American Humor—even if those events take place offsite.

There will be "sufficient continuing engagement with the artistic community, the

donor base, and patrons, that a two-year closure of the main building will not unduly affect

its ability to ramp up programming in a revitalized main building in 2028," according to the resolution put before the Board.

Those programs may preserve some continuity, but reopening the main building will present a different challenge. Canning says that much of the damage to the Center's reputation has already been done.

"The cost is to everyone, not just folks in D.C.," Canning says. "The loss is bad now, but it's going to get increasingly worse in the future."

Because ticket sales are an important source of revenue, Canning says financial recovery after a prolonged closure will take time. That recovery will also depend on rehiring staff and rebuilding the programming calendar.

"All the expert employees they had—the best ones—have all found other jobs and may be very unwilling to return to a much more tenuous employment situation like the Kennedy Center," she says.

“And the artists that they routinely booked will have adapted their schedules.”

“It's very easy to destroy something—that can be done in literally a year,” Canning adds. “Rebuilding is much, much, much more difficult.”

Senators speak out on Congress recess, Hegseth and Kennedy Center woes

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https://time.com/article/2026/09/15/kennedy-center-board-approves-immediate-2-year-building-closure/

U.S. | Education

The Woman Winning the Reading Wars

About 700,000 teachers have enrolled in the intensive reading course written by Moats, pictured outside her home in rural VermontJohn Tully for TIME

Louisa Moats was at a conference in Daphne, Ala., earlier this year when she was approached by a group of teachers. For the 81-year-old, this was a relatively new occurrence. “They’re poorly paid, they don’t look very healthy, they certainly didn’t have an elite education and I feel this concern and admiration for them as they do this job,” she says, with her characteristic frankness. “They come up to me, with this glazed, starry-eyed look, and thank me as

if I, personally, was the conduit to their renewed sense of purpose and competence. I get that a lot now."

Moats has become a late-in-life heroine, at least in some circles, because of a teacher-training program she wrote decades ago that has become a buzzy property. She is not exactly basking in the attention. "I take it with a grain of salt," she says, sitting in her remote Vermont lake house. "Behind that is my sense that what I would want them to do is probably not exactly what's going on in their classroom, but it's a reasonable enough approximation that it's making a difference for kids."

Her skepticism can be forgiven. For a long time, Moats found herself on the losing side of America's so-called reading wars, the back-and-forth over the best way to teach kids to read. She and her cohort of researchers promote the idea that reading is a skill that must be painstakingly taught, first through an understanding of the way sounds make up speech and get represented as letters, then through explicit instruction on how language works. But the prevailing view, until a few years ago, was that most children would figure out how to decode the letters if given enough encouragement, stimulating material, and context clues, just as they do with speech.

"This is still something I ponder all the time," Moats says, about why schools chose to teach the way they did. One explanation she has landed on: people did not keep up with the research. "Usually they have not sat down and looked at the evidence—the nature of the evidence, the scope of the evidence, the durability of the evidence—and so they don't understand what the science is about."

Interest in "the science" has recently increased dramatically, alongside the level of panic about literacy rates in the U.S. About 4 in 10 American children have not mastered basic reading-comprehension skills by fourth grade, the worst result in 20 years,

according to the 2024 National Assessment of Educational Progress (NAEP). A third of eighth-graders also fall below the reading level expected for their age. The average 12th-grader scores three points lower on a reading test than his or her peers did in 2019, and 10 points lower than those from 1992.

Some of that can be laid at the door of school closures during the pandemic. But it's a problem with deeper roots: roughly a quarter of young adults (16 to 24) are functionally illiterate, according to the National Center for Education Statistics. Professors bemoan having to assign ever-shorter reading assignments. Time-use surveys report that people from 20 to 34 spend no more than 10 minutes a day reading for pleasure. Grave declarations have proclaimed the "end of reading."

To combat the decline, states have looked to the few education districts where students are showing improvement and followed their example by enacting what are known as science-of-reading laws. The laws, which have been passed in 42 states and D.C., mostly in the past seven years, mandate that schools use very structured techniques—including foundational instruction on phonics. Many teachers did not learn this approach in college and have to be retrained.

Moats' program, Language Essentials for Teachers of Reading and Spelling (LETRS), has become the preferred way for schools to meet the requirements. The course is famously long and rigorous. Teachers must delve into language theory and cognitive science before any advice on instruction is given. It isolates 19 vowel sounds and 29 consonant sounds in U.S. English. Moats' ideas are generally associated with phonology (how words sound), but the program goes deeply into morphology (how words are built of parts) and orthography (how words are written). It's also relatively pricey. Public contracts and appropriations suggest statewide LETRS rollouts cost up to $1,700 per educator, before factoring in substitute teachers, planning time, coaching, and administration.

And it’s not clear that all the knowledge translates into better teaching methods.

Moats in a class of middle-school students in Clayton County, Georgia, in 2018Courtesy Voyager Sopris Learning/Lexia Learning

But that hasn’t stopped 23 states from purchasing the program, and at least one, Alabama, from paying teachers $1,000 if they did all of it. In 2020, fewer than 25,000 teachers had enrolled in the 155-hour course, according to Lexia, the company that now owns it. In 2025, that number reached 700,000, mostly lower elementary. (There are approximately 1.5 million K-5 educators in the U.S., according to the Bureau of Labor Statistics.) Michigan, whose recent standardized test results showed 38.2% of third-graders were proficient in reading, announced this summer it was spending $75 million so that every reading teacher could do the course. (It has already spent $44 million on teachers who did it voluntarily.) “The last three years, I have seen more money from this than I ever expected to see from it,” says Moats, who earns what she calls “a small royalty” on each sale.

Still, whether out of native New England reticence or because she’s almost sure she’s seen this movie before, Moats, now allegedly retired, regards this turn of events with mild suspicion. “It’s humbling, it’s a bit bewildering, it’s a bit surrealistic,” she says. Finally, when asked directly, she adds, “and yes, it’s very gratifying.” Educators may dismiss the idea of the reading wars, claiming teaching is not an us-vs.-them endeavor, but if they are

real—and it looks like they are—it sure seems that Moats has emerged as a victor.

She intended to be a folk singer. But having graduated from Wellesley College with a degree in music, Moats needed a job, and her sister got her one in Boston, with a researcher in the emerging field of neuropsychology, who needed people to type up reports. He also needed a lab technician, so he gave Moats a white coat and trained her to administer tests. “That’s how I learned to think about the kids with learning disabilities who were sent to our clinic,” she says. “I learned how to think of them through this neurological lens.”

When Vanderbilt University’s Peabody College offered one of the first fellowships for a master’s in learning disabilities, Moats jumped at the chance to move to Nashville. “I tromped up and down Music Row and got a contract as a songwriter and got a master’s degree in learning disabilities,” she says. “It was fun, and it was completely worthless as far as learning how to teach.” Armed with a balance beam, a chalkboard, and some visual aids, she was hired to “cure” learning disabilities in local schools. “The experience of the total disconnect between what I learned in a master’s program and the realities of the kids and their needs,” she says, has given her sympathy for teachers now realizing that the reading-instruction methods they learned in college might be flawed.

Even though her music career was progressing (she had a songwriting contract with Screen Gems) and her career in special education was opening doors (she had a parent-teacher meeting with Johnny Cash), Moats was not a Nashville type. She found the music industry predatory and missed the snow. (Her daughter Charlotte would later become a Junior Olympics ski champion.) She moved back to her old job at Tufts–New England Medical Center and claims she more or less fell into a doctorate at Harvard,

where she encountered the terrifying but brilliant linguist Carol Chomsky, wife of Noam, and Jeanne Chall, after whom Harvard's reading lab is named. "Chall was the one who got me into understanding how to look at spelling errors in a very detailed and informed way," says Moats.

She began to observe that children who couldn't read or spell just did not register the relationship between the sounds in a word and the letters. They struggled especially when the words sounded a little alike but were spelled very differently, as in *juice* and *choose*, or spelled alike but pronounced differently as in the s sound in *was* and *saw*. Moats came to believe teaching kids to read entails understanding a lot more about the brain and language processing than the average teacher knows.

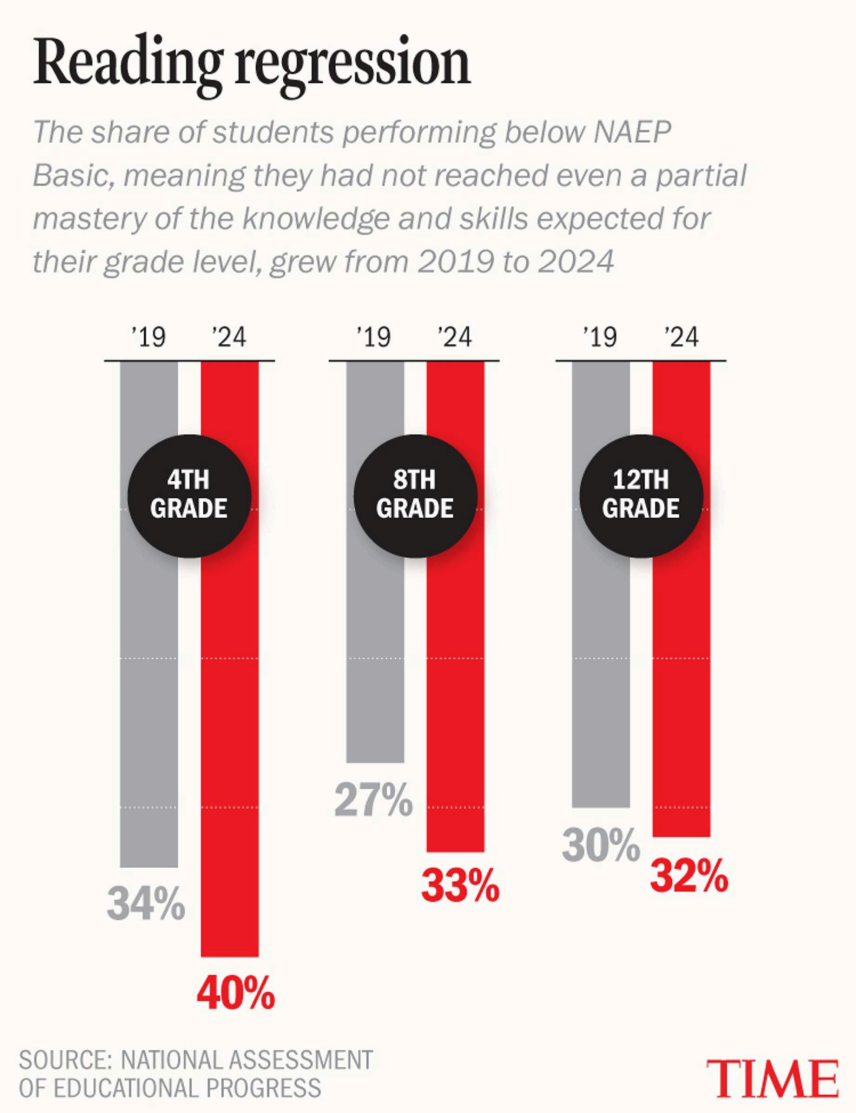
In the mid-1980s, after a few years of helping struggling readers, from impoverished children to Dartmouth academics, in her private practice in East Thetford, Vt., Moats realized that earlier intervention was needed. So she began to teach teachers, at Harvard and at smaller Vermont colleges. She gave her incoming postgraduates surveys. "The results were appalling," she says. "They didn't know anything." Many had been taught the whole-language theory of reading, which suggested that teaching students to decode words distracted them from understanding their meaning, and therefore students should learn the words as a unit, not by blending graphemes. She wrote an academic paper about it, which was republished by the American Federation of Teachers in 1995.

A few years earlier, another literacy researcher, G. Reid Lyon, had been put in charge of creating and overseeing a federally funded reading-research network, a large multisite program that investigated how children learn to read and why some don't. He asked Moats to help. "What I needed was a leader and a teacher and a teacher of teachers, which she was extraordinary at," says Lyon, also now retired in Vermont. "A lot of professors can get up there and quack away, but they don't really have the wherewithal to

demonstrate it. She did." Moats was assigned to the Washington, D.C., site.

"Boy, did I have impostor syndrome," she says. "Here I was in this room full of eminences, and I had been reading their work, I'd been citing them, I'd been learning from them." She also had some hard lessons to learn as a northeastern hippie in a majority-Black school district. "I just couldn't believe the state of affairs in these schools," says Moats. "Libraries with no books, no doors on the lavatory, no running water in the sinks." She labored to get the teachers to trust her. Eventually, one of her assistants took her aside. "She said, 'You're the director, you've got to look like the director,'" recalls Moats, who favors denim and heavy glasses. "I said, 'You have any advice?' She said, 'Go to Ann Taylor.'" The project was a success, her nine schools' reading rates soared, and local politicians started to drop by for photo opportunities.

Then national politicians took notice too. The No Child Left Behind Act that President George W. Bush signed in 2002 enshrined the work of Lyon's team and the National Reading Panel. Moats was tapped to write the teacher-training component of the act's Reading First initiative, which became LETRS.



Lon Tweeten for TIME

Reading First was expensive—about a billion dollars was spent on a few million children—and the law mandated that a report be made of how effective it was by 2008. The news was not great. While students had been taught in a way that research had said was most effective, and first-graders did decode words better, elementary students as a whole were not better at understanding what they read than the students who were not part of the initiative. An Institute of Education Sciences (IES) report on LETRS in particular found that while the training improved teachers' understanding of language, it did not improve outcomes for students.

Moats is still steaming about that analysis. “You don’t get an impact on student achievement after one year,” she says. “You’ve barely gotten through the professional-development material.” She also notes that after four years of Reading First, many state-level reading analyses showed improvement, especially in high-poverty regions. Nevertheless, Reading First’s funding was not renewed, and states were allowed to go their own way with reading instruction.

It is perhaps reductive to boil this history down to a battle between two women. But it is also true that around the time Moats and her colleagues were doing their work, another approach was ascendant, championed largely by a figure with a lot of the kind of main-character energy that Moats lacks. The founder of the Teachers College Reading and Writing Project (TCRWP) at Columbia University, Lucy Calkins, promulgated the idea of balanced literacy, which purported to be a détente between the phonics camp and the whole-language advocates. Calkins, whose background was in writing instruction, believed that children first of all needed enticing books at a level they could manage and a ton of cheerleading. “I always knew phonics mattered,” Calkins says now. “When kids write, every single minute of what they’re doing shows their phonics.” Nevertheless, the curriculum materials she authored had little phonics, and suggested that teachers use a separate phonics course.

“A lot of people who have a casual acquaintance with the research have persuaded themselves that balanced reading instruction means a little of this, a little of that,” Moats wrote in a seminal essay about balanced literacy in 2000. “Take a cup of phonics from one cupboard, add a half-pint of whole language from the fridge, and the resulting blend will succeed with children while avoiding the battles and conflicts of the ‘reading wars.’ Everyone will be happy, and all will be well. The problem is that it doesn’t work that way.”

This was the world that Margaret Goldberg was introduced to after she completed her master's degree at UC Berkeley. In 2015, she arrived at a Title I Oakland school and quickly found that the methods she used in higher-performing schools just down the road did not work. After discovering Moats' essay via Google, she started using more structured literacy methods with some of her classes and took a balanced-literacy approach with others. "I didn't realize that I was teaching on both sides of the reading wars," says Goldberg, who co-founded the Right to Read Project in 2019. The results were stark. "All of the ideals of balanced literacy were happening with the kids who were being taught systematically and explicitly how to decode. The students I was teaching balanced literacy to—I was just trying to sell them on reading."

Eventually, parents, especially those with dyslexic children, who tend to need more explicit phonics instruction, began to protest. Mississippi, which gave all its K-3 teachers LETRS training starting in 2014, was the first state to improve its numbers. By 2019, its fourth-grade NAEP reading score had risen 10 points from 2013—the largest gain of any state during that period. LETRS wasn't the sole reason for Mississippi's success. The state also added new practices around teacher coaching and accountability, more student screening and intervention, and held back a bunch of third-graders. But the teacher training was key.

Meanwhile, public-radio journalist Emily Hanford amassed enough evidence against the balanced-literacy methodology to publish a 2018 audio documentary that would become her influential *Sold a Story* podcast. Politicians, administrators, and even teachers' colleges took heed. But change, especially to higher education, came slowly. Carol Tolman, one of the co-authors of later versions of LETRS, was an early trainer in the program. At one college, she says, "there was a letter on my podium, just saying, 'We don't need the likes of you here. As soon as you leave, this is all going to change and go back.' I mean, it got really heated."

“The evidence for what works with kids has been there for more than 30 years,” says MoatsJohn Tully for TIME

Alabama piloted the use of LETRS in 2018, and expanded it to the whole state in 2021, by which time South Carolina and North Carolina were also jumping on board. In 2022 they were joined by Kentucky and Arkansas. In 2021 North Carolina approved almost $50 million to train its K-5 educators using LETRS. Not all of them appreciated it. “I’m all for the science of reading. I’m all for providing structured sequence materials to teachers,” says John Davis, who did the training as a third-grade teacher. But he knew a lot of the material already. And the main curriculum used in his school was not aligned with LETRS methodology. “You spent all this money and time on this training, and it’s not showing up in our reading curriculum?” says Davis. “It just seems like a waste.”

Even Calkins came around—a bit. She rereleased her curriculum materials a few times, adding more phonics emphasis, but criticism of some of the methods she recommended mounted, and after Columbia University detached itself from TCRWP in 2023, she founded her own institute. “I am all for what I’ve learned from the science of reading, and also the new relationships I’ve developed and the new organizations I belong to now,” she says. “All that’s

been helpful, but it’s awful to have teachers teaching in ways they don’t believe in.”

Indeed, the prospect of yet more mandatory training brought many teachers zero joy. Lisa Anderson was one of them. She had been an elementary teacher in Minnesota for more than 20 years when she was required in 2022 to undertake LETRS. “Another hurdle, something more to jump through,” she says. “The pendulum’s swinging, we jump on, and let’s see where this one lands.”

That feeling lasted until about halfway into Volume 2. Before she’d even completed the program, she began to implement some of its methods—the school was also using a different curriculum that was more aligned with LETRS ideas—and saw surprising results. Students were starting to read, even many who were floundering. A new emotion emerged: anger. Why had she never been shown this information before? She was moved to write to her alma mater, Bemidji State, and demand a refund of the fees associated with the courses she had taken on teaching children to read. “You didn’t do your job,” she says she told them. (A spokesperson told TIME that the college continually updates its curriculum in accordance with state standards.)

While LETRS’ success has assured Moats a comfortable retirement, she is still hoping that it will pay other dividends. “I hope that maybe we’re getting beyond the reading wars,” she says, meaning that the correct way to teach reading has been established. “But I don’t feel that secure about what it is I’m trying to teach actually taking hold. I think people do the course, but they don’t realize the power of the information.”

Sitting on a chair in her dining room, not far from the guitar on another one, is a spelling sheet from a second-grade child in California that a teacher has sent through asking for help. Moats sighs deeply as she reads it. (“She sighs *a lot*,” says Lyon.) The

child has written all the *-igh* words (*thigh*, *high*, *fight*) like *-ing* words (*thing*, *hing*, *fing*). “He’s trying to memorize letters by their appearance. He has no idea about the correspondence between speech and print,” she says. Even today, five or more years after the science-of-reading revolution began and decades after the Reading Panel, “this teacher cannot look at these writing samples and recognize poor phoneme awareness.” (Surveys suggest that even with all the legislation and training, no more than half of K-3 teachers are using science-of-reading techniques.)

LETRS is also hitting critical mass just as Moats cedes control over the quality of the training, to the consternation of some of the earlier employees. “The mission became the money,” says Leta Palmiter, a former LETRS trainer who joined the company shortly after Lexia was bought by the private-equity firm Veritas Capital in 2020. “Not the people who received the training.” A Lexia spokesperson says improving literacy “remains at the heart of everything we do.”

It’s too soon to tell—especially with the interruptions caused by the pandemic clouding the data—whether any of the states that have newly adopted LETRS have managed to improve the reading skills of their students. And even if they do, it will be difficult to tell how much LETRS is responsible. A $4 million five-year randomized study of its effect is under way, but the results will not be available until 2029. A recent analysis by the Kentucky Department of Education found that schools with higher rates of LETRS-trained teachers posted larger gains in reading proficiency than schools with lower rates, but it was an internal study. Meanwhile, NAEP reading scores ticked up a few points for 9-year-olds in 2025 (although not for 13-year-olds), and another national report showed improvement in K-8 reading skills from 2025 to 2026. “I think all this work can only help,” says David Liben, a literacy consultant and one of the authors of the 2010 Common Core standards. “I just don’t think that at this point we have the evidence that we can make a claim that we’re turning a corner now.”

Experts agree that teacher training alone is not a solution for America's reading ills. "This idea that nobody was teaching phonics, it just is absurd," says former director of reading for Chicago Public Schools Timothy Shanahan, whose recent book *Leveled Reading, Leveled Lives* takes aim at balanced literacy, but who is also not sold on its replacement. For every Mississippi, he says, there's a state like Arkansas, where LETRS hasn't seemed to make any difference. And the tight focus on teacher training has come at a cost to other urgent problems in education, like truancy. "Is it that the kids are getting poor instruction, or that our attendance levels are so low right now that kids just aren't learning?" he asks.

Mistakes in education take a long time to show up, and so do fixes. By the time the students who learned how to read from LETRS-trained teachers are in the workforce, the landscape for communication may be unrecognizable. Even now, reading is not as vital to thriving as it was a mere five years ago. There are remarkable new ways to glean information and disperse it. Generative AI can write for us, and books can be read aloud by machines, so some of the disadvantages of being illiterate may be overcome by technology.

But the ability to recognize and manipulate written words will still be a critical skill, say most educators, because it is inextricably linked to thinking. Decades of research in psychology, neuroscience, linguistics, and education suggest that becoming literate changes how people reason, solve problems, organize knowledge, and deliberate on their own thinking. "The mental work that is reading," says Moats, "is the essence of learning."

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https://time.com/article/2026/09/23/louisa-moats-letrs-training-reading-interview/

World

- **Carney Says Canada and E.U. 'Are Not Fair Weather Allies'**
  "I'm not proposing a third bloc in order to become a 'great power' rival, only with better manners," Carney quipped, as he seeks to strengthen ties between Canada and the European Union.
- **Exclusive: Myanmar's Dictator Wants to Rebuild Ties With the West**
  In his first Western media interview since seizing power, Min Aung Hlaing makes his case for engagement as Myanmar's civil war grinds on.

World | Canada

Carney Says Canada and E.U. 'Are Not Fair Weather Allies'

Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney on Thursday welcomed the prospect of Canada becoming an “associate member” of the E.U., just hours after U.S. President Donald Trump dismissed the proposal as “laughable.”

Addressing the European Parliament as a guest of honor in Strasbourg, France, Carney insisted “Europe and Canada are stronger together” and said “Canada and the European Union can anchor our ground to hold our values while forming a protective canopy under which our citizens can thrive.”

Carney’s pivot toward Europe comes as he seeks to establish stronger international ties and curtail Canada’s reliance on the American market amid an all-out trade war. Canada’s retaliatory tariffs came into effect last week, matching the economic pressure imposed by the U.S. after negotiations collapsed last month. Trump’s repeated threats against Canadian sovereignty and calls to make it the “51st state” have added to the months-long tension.

While Carney did not directly mention Trump or his Administration while addressing European lawmakers, he appeared to make nods to the current volatility of Canada-U.S. relations and condemned economic coercions. Speaking about the "current geopolitical rupture," he said a "new dimension was needed.”

“Economic integration is now being weaponized, tariffs being used to exert pressure,” he said. “Financial mechanisms have been used for coercion. Supply chains constitute weak points to be exploited.”

Championing the burgeoning E.U. alliance, Carney focused on what he said were shared values between Canada and the bloc, insisting: "We are not fair-weather allies. We believe that our prosperity grows when it is shared."

“I'm not proposing a third bloc in order to become a 'great power' rival, only with better manners,” Carney continued. “We do not seek power to dominate others. On the contrary, we are pursuing resilience so no one can control our open markets, impair our sovereignty, threaten our territorial integrity, or undermine our freedoms, our democracies, our rule of law.”

Carney, who began his speech in French—one of Canada’s official languages—before continuing in English, with splatterings of German, welcomed how European Commission president Ursula von der Leyen had on Wednesday opened the door for Canada becoming an “associate member” of the 27-member bloc.

When speaking about forging closer ties with the E.U., Carney referenced seeking strategic autonomy through “deep co-operation in the full range of strategic capabilities, including critical minerals, defense industrial capacity, AI and compute, energy security, space and payments.” He insisted Canada and Europe must not be dependent on “individual nations or individual companies” as this “creates vulnerabilities, particularly when supposedly global companies prove national in the breach.”

He also hinted at a potential freedom of movement between the E.U. and Canada that would allow “youth to work, study, and live where they want, on either side of the Atlantic.”

Carney’s passionate advocacy for the deepening of ties with the E.U.—a move he says Canadians have shown they’re in support of—came after Trump lambasted the idea of a new European dawn for Canada.

Speaking to reporters Wednesday, Trump called the proposal “laughable” and threatened economic punishments if the E.U. moves forward with von der Leyen’s plan.

"If they do that, if I think it's at all a hostile act, I will put very serious tariffs or stop trading with Europe on many things," Trump said en route to an event in North Carolina. "If it's a good intention, that's fine. If it's a bad intention, we'll put very heavy tariffs on Europe.”

In response to Trump’s remarks, a European Commission spokesperson told TIME: “As president von der Leyen made clear [on Wednesday], the proposed strengthening of our partnership with Canada is not against anyone else, but for our common strength.”

Carney welcomes new alliances on visit to Europe

Carney's speech to the European Parliament came on the final day of his stay in Europe, where he sought to cement and deepen Canada’s international relationships.

The E.U. is Canada’s second-largest global trading partner for goods and services, with bilateral trade worth approximately C$178.6 billion in 2025.

The Canadian leader also traveled to Liverpool, England, to meet British Prime Minister Andy Burnham. The pair attended a football game and watched Everton—the team they both support—secure a victory against the Wolverhampton Wanderers.

"The leaders began by underscoring the close co-operation between the U.K. and Canada and emphasized the importance of building similar close ties with European partners, particularly on trade and defence,” a Downing Street spokeswoman told TIME.

Ahead of the meeting, Burnham called Carney a “great progressive leader” with whom the U.K. shares “so many values, but also with whom we have a shared opportunity on defense co-operation, on trade” and AI.

Canada applies to join U.K.-led military coalition

Following Burnham and Carney's meeting, it was announced that Canada has applied to join the British-led Joint Expeditionary Force military coalition.

The force, formally launched in 2014, consists of 10 North Atlantic NATO member states that deliver rapid response and security operations.

“Prime Minister Carney announced that Canada has formally applied to join the Joint Expeditionary Force and welcomed the U.K.’s support for Canada’s participation in this important initiative,” Carney’s office said in a statement.

Canada, already a NATO member, is seeking to diversify its defense dependency from the U.S. with new partnerships across the Atlantic.

In February, Canada became the first non-European country to participate in the "Security action for Europe” (SAFE) instrument, which provides up to €150 billion in low-interest loans to help member states purchase military and defense equipment.

What happens next as Canada seeks "associate" membership with the E.U.?

Following von der Leyen’s proposal, a European Commission spokesperson told TIME that the executive cabinet will work “in close coordination with [its] member states and the European

Parliament" to "create a new form of partnership that has not existed until now–building the closest imaginable form of association with a partner outside Europe."

The proposed alliance is set to include deeper economic ties, a technology alliance, greater integration of defense industrial bases, and efforts to make the Arctic a flagship joint project. It could also expand cooperation on energy, critical minerals and batteries, as well as AI, quantum technology, cybersecurity, and economic security.

The E.U.-Canada summit set to take place in Montreal in late October will "provide the first meaningful opportunity to discuss these issues further," the spokesperson told TIME.

The proposal has been welcomed by many European lawmakers across the bloc.

Member of the European Parliament (MEP) for Spain Javier Moreno Sánchez, who also serves as chair of the parliament's delegation for relations with Canada, told TIME the decision to bring Canada in as an "associate member" was "politically and symbolically significant," but warned it "must now be followed by concrete actions."

Irish MEP Barry Andrews told TIME that the announcement is a clear "win-win for both sides," adding that "in an ever more insecure world, truly democratic countries must come together and stand up to Trump, [Chinese President] Xi Jinping, and [Russian President Vladimir] Putin."

Germany, the E.U.'s largest economy, also embraced the move, with government spokesperson Stefan Kornelius saying Berlin "welcomes the initiative for a particularly close partnership with Canada."

The E.U., much like Canada, is seeking new partnerships amid a weakening alliance with the U.S. under Trump, following disputes over tariff threats, his lashing out at the NATO alliance, and his push to annex Greenland.

Espen Barth Eide, Norway's Foreign Affairs Minister, told TIME the world is "living through the most serious security situation since the Second World War."

"At a time like this, it is welcome that the E.U. is strengthening cooperation on European security. We also welcome the E.U.'s efforts to involve Norway, the United Kingdom, Canada and Iceland. Such an approach strengthens European security," he said.

Norway and Iceland are not members of the E.U., but both belong to the European Economic Area (EEA), giving them close economic ties to the bloc through trade and free movement—a model from which Canada could draw inspiration.

Elsewhere, the "associate" membership proposal faced backlash.

French MEP Manon Aubry, co-chair of The Left group, told TIME there was "a serious question of method," arguing that "a decision of such magnitude cannot be made by the president of the European Commission alone."

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https://time.com/article/2026/09/17/canada-european-union-membership-carney-trump-tariff-threats/

World | myanmar

Exclusive: Myanmar’s Dictator Wants to Rebuild Ties With the West

Min Aung Hlaing inside the Presidential office on Aug. 28, 2026, in Naypyidaw.Photograph by Jes Aznar for TIME

First came the mirror. Before Min Aung Hlaing enters the room for his first Western media interview since seizing power in a 2021 coup d’état, aides maneuver an ornate Rococo revival looking glass into place for preening. Then come requests for his portrait: light him from the left, the better to disguise a thinning hairline no longer hidden beneath an olive cap.

Myanmar's former commander in chief now calls himself President, following January elections widely condemned as fraudulent. His fitful transformation from generalissimo to civilian statesman extends even to awkward attempts at bonhomie. He confesses to loving golf—he plays off an 18 handicap—though a bad back has lately kept him from the fairway.

Yet the makeover has limits. The geniality fades when questions turn to human rights, narcotics trafficking, or sanctioned relatives. Even his birthplace remains classified. "I used to revisit my township very often, so if you can carefully watch the news, you can figure out where I'm native," he says cryptically.

Min Aung Hlaing may have swapped his uniform for a silken *longyi* sarong, but the barracks instinct to conceal, deflect, and command remains firmly in place. "Some of my responses didn't directly touch upon your questions, but I hope they were still useful," he offers after our hour together.

Obfuscation is a curious tactic for someone fixated on ingratiating himself with the international community. While his coup was widely condemned, Min Aung Hlaing has now ruled Myanmar for five years, and there is a growing realization that he is going nowhere. He has now been welcomed on official visits to nine nations, and while autocracies like Russia and China might warrant an eye roll, trips to broadly democratic Thailand and India indicate a wider thaw.

For neighbors, engagement is born of necessity: Myanmar is not only the world's top producer of methamphetamine and opium, but also the nerve center of a global "scamdemic" that loots unsuspecting bank accounts to the tune of $15 billion annually. "The situation in Myanmar is having a global impact," says Jeremy Douglas, deputy director of operations at the U.N. Office on Drugs and Crime. "It's off the charts, and the region needs to intervene before it gets worse."

Students play on a naval gun at the Defense Services Museum in Naypyidaw.

The quandary facing Western powers is whether to follow suit. Myanmar is also among the world's most resource rich nations, boasting vast deposits of jade, copper, coal, teak, gemstones, tin, and gold. And it is the world's third largest producer of heavy rare earths—arcane materials over which Washington and Beijing continue to spar.

Yet the reputational stakes of cozying up to Min Aung Hlaing may eclipse these riches. The Southeast Asian nation of 55 million, formerly known as Burma, remains racked by civil war between forces loyal to his government, ethnic rebel groups, and a National Unity Government (NUG) spawned from the ousted administration of democracy icon Aung San Suu Kyi, who remains in detention. Today, Min Aung Hlaing controls less than half of Myanmar's total landmass.

"Our strategy has been expanding our territory and providing necessary social welfare and essential services," says Duwa Lashi La, acting President of the NUG. "We also protect the public from the junta's attacks."

The conflict has so far claimed more than 100,000 lives, displaced 3.6 million people, and sent countless others fleeing across

Myanmar’s borders. Troops under Min Aung Hlaing’s command stand accused of torching villages, massacring civilians, and committing sexual violence, while fighter aircraft and drones have targeted schools and temples. U.N. investigators have accused him of genocide, war crimes, and ethnic cleansing. He denies wrongdoing.

While the Biden Administration rhetorically backed the NUG, U.S. President Donald Trump has anchored foreign policy in transactional interests. On June 25, U.S. Assistant Secretary of State for East Asian and Pacific Affairs Michael DeSombre noted that Washington is “very open to working with all stakeholders” to combat “mass displacement and trans-national crime.” Last year, the Trump Administration withdrew sanctions on several junta allies amid a Myanmar policy review that looks likely to advocate revived ties. It has already ended temporary protected status for nearly 4,000 refugees. “It is safe for Burmese citizens to return home,” then Homeland Security Secretary Kristi Noem said in November.

Fulsome engagement will “infuriate a large portion of the Myanmar population,” says Scot Marciel, U.S. ambassador to Myanmar from 2016 to 2020. “But I don’t think Trump and company care.”

Devotees pray and make offerings at the Shwedagon pagoda in Yangon.

As ever, a key driver is countering the growing clout of China, which covets Myanmar's resources as well as strategic access to the Bay of Bengal. But Beijing's approach has been scattergun: it considers Suu Kyi an "old friend," yet has supplied rebel forces as well as backing Min Aung Hlaing—a diplomatic fudge critics say underscores the perils of replacing a values-based U.S. approach with a transactional, Chinese-led regional order.

"It's hard to ascribe a clear strategy for China in Myanmar," says Drew Thompson, a former U.S. defense official now at the S. Rajaratnam School of International Studies in Singapore. "It's contributed to instability by not creating a preponderance of power in any one place."

The gamble is whether engagement could tease Myanmar from China's orbit and achieve more than years of condemnation has. Sanctions, the argument goes, have not prevented foreign firms from operating in the country, nor would they block U.S. companies from re-entering. Under this real-politik, Washington's demands would be concrete: lower tariffs on American goods, curb scam networks targeting Americans, and deny China access to critical infrastructure. Political reform, meanwhile, would be back-burnered.

A revised Myanmar policy is far from a priority for the U.S. "There would have to be some tangible economic benefit to really bother," says Marciel. Min Aung Hlaing has enlisted influential people to make that case; lobbyist Roger Stone—a Trump confidant—is being paid $50,000 a month to help "rebuild" relations with D.C., according to official filings.

"I'd be very surprised if the U.S. doesn't re-engage with the junta," says Jonah Blank, a Southeast Asia analyst and former Senate Foreign Relations Committee staffer. "None of the things that held

back previous administrations, like human rights or democracy promotion, mean a thing."

Yet engagement would also erase much of America's moral authority in the region. Min Aung Hlaing isn't shy in his hope that America First nativism offers him a lifeline: "It would be ideal if the U.S. could cooperate with us in fostering the peace, stability, and development essential for our people to successfully realize a fully democratic state."

The last phrase hangs awkwardly here in the capital Naypyidaw, a labyrinthine citadel built by the military in 2005 to insulate itself from unrest. "There are various forms of democracy," Min Aung Hlaing says with a thin smile. "There is American democracy, there is European democracy. I will ensure that Myanmar achieves a democratic system that truly aligns with our own culture, customs, and traditions."

Those traditions are on full display a short drive from Min Aung Hlaing's office, where Myanmar's Defense Services Museum sprawls across 600 manicured acres. Buses of schoolchildren streaked with golden *thanaka* paste—a traditional sunscreen and beauty adornment—clamber over decommissioned fighter jets, tanks, and anti-aircraft guns.

The Myanmar military's suffocating political role calcified after General Ne Win staged a coup in 1962. Min Aung Hlaing was 5 at the time, growing up in the northern city of Mandalay. He says he wasn't always keen to attend school, "but my mother made absolutely sure that I did." This inculcated a love of literature, he says, but after attending university in Yangon, he abandoned his law studies to pursue a military career, gaining admission to the elite Defence Services Academy on his third attempt in 1974.

A vendor sells vegetables on a street in Mandalay.

Waitresses clean a table at a cafe in Mandalay.

Min Aung Hlaing's formative environment was Ne Win's military machine—an institution that regarded itself as sole guardian of unity, sovereignty, and political order. "The military is an integral part of the nation," he says, "and military personnel and their families are a part of the people."

Former classmates recall an average cadet of below—average charm—a reserved, disciplined, and politically cautious officer who accumulated influence through institutional loyalty, bureaucratic persistence, and the careful management of military elites. His profile rose in 2009 when he led a campaign to subdue ethnic insurgents in the Kokang region along the Chinese border.

The offensive ended a two-decade cease-fire and sent some 30,000 people fleeing into China. While the episode angered Beijing, it burnished Min Aung Hlaing's leadership credentials and spurred successive promotions.

It was a strange moment in Myanmar. The old junta run by another military dictator, Senior General Than Shwe, was nominally stepping back, easing censorship, and releasing political prisoners, including Suu Kyi, who eventually assumed executive power as state counselor. Min Aung Hlaing presented himself as a professional soldier supporting a carefully managed transition. He cultivated foreign military relationships, met diplomats, and posed with monks. The once taciturn officer increasingly behaved like a politician.

When Suu Kyi's National League for Democracy (NLD) won a landslide in 2015, President Barack Obama lifted all remaining U.S. economic sanctions. The country Suu Kyi inherited had been hollowed out by half a century of dysfunction. Southeast Asia's richest economy upon independence in 1948, Myanmar had become by some metrics its poorest—its banks insolvent, bureaucracy broken, and corruption endemic. Suu Kyi tapped Australian economist Sean Turnell to help reverse that decline. Reforms curbed inflation and deficits, opened the country to investment, and expanded micro-finance to 6 million borrowers, overwhelmingly women.

Yet civilian control was a mirage: the 2008 constitution guaranteed a quarter of legislative seats for the military, which also nominated the ministers of defense, home affairs, and border affairs. Reform unfolded inside a constitutional cage. Civilian leaders could redirect spending toward schools and hospitals, but they could not restrain the generals, overcome weak institutions, or decentralize power. "There was still a military mindset that Burma is a victim, and the perpetrators are always invidious foreigners," says Turnell.

“The international economy was an arena of threat rather than opportunity.”

A nadir was reached in 2016 with military operations that the U.S. subsequently deemed genocide against the Rohingya, a predominantly Muslim minority concentrated in Rakhine state. Myanmar denies the Rohingya constitute an Indigenous ethnic group, commonly referring to them as “Bengalis” and portraying them as interlopers from Bangladesh.

Attacks on security posts by Rohingya militants the next year prompted counterterrorism “clearance operations” that saw hundreds of villages burned amid accusations of mass executions and rape. More than 700,000 fled across the Bangladeshi border, while a U.N. fact-finding mission conservatively estimates up to 10,000 were killed. An International Criminal Court prosecutor sought Min Aung Hlaing’s arrest for crimes against humanity, while a separate Argentine warrant also accuses him of genocide. “We have not committed any such acts against the Bengalis in Rakhine state,” he says. “Our actions were strictly limited to safeguarding our country’s sovereignty. Our conscience is entirely clear.”

Peanut farmers working on their plots in Mandalay.

A local family visits a shopping mall in Mandalay.

Min Aung Hlaing had an incongruous ally in Nobel laureate Suu Kyi, who took the remarkable step of defending Myanmar's military at the Hague, where she urged the bench to "bear in mind this complex situation and the challenge to sovereignty and security." The international community was aghast and stripped her of numerous honors. "She was desperately trying not to rock the boat," says Mon Mon Myat, a former democracy activist and Suu Kyi biographer.

Yet Suu Kyi's performance also angered Myanmar's top brass, who deemed her defense lukewarm after she raised the possibility of courts-martial for military transgressors. "It was the wrong strategy," says Aung Zaw, a former student activist and founder of the Thailand-based magazine *The Irrawaddy.* "She was seen as defending the regime at the Hague, but then the military also weren't happy."

That animosity exploded in November 2020 when the NLD won another landslide. While the Carter Center rated the process "very good" or "reasonable" at 95% of observed polling stations, Min Aung Hlaing alleges rampant fraud, calling it "one of the most disgraceful elections in democratic history."

On Feb. 1, 2021, a convoy of black military vehicles rolled through Naypyidaw to detain top NLD leaders. Suu Kyi was sentenced to 33 years (now reduced to 18) on charges ranging from corruption to illegally possessing walkie-talkies. “I have been extremely lenient toward her,” Min Aung Hlaing says with a straight face. “We made every possible effort to prevent the situation from reaching this point.”

What really drove Min Aung Hlaing to seize power dominated discussions among officials in squalid detention. “We talked about it a lot,” says Turnell, who spent 650 days in custody. “There was certainly a part of the military that didn’t want any loosening of the sort under way.”

The coup is best understood as a reaction to a regime losing control. According to a leaked 2004 military dossier, the junta engineered reforms to hedge against Beijing’s overbearing influence and leverage Suu Kyi’s freedom to win Western trade, aid, and diplomatic legitimacy. But the generals miscalculated the public’s fierce devotion to “The Lady,” whose popularity proved fundamentally incompatible with the military’s absolute power. Myanmar’s military also has sprawling business interests spanning banking, mining, gems, construction, manufacturing, tobacco, tourism, transport, telecoms, and real estate. Reforms threatened this gravy train.

It is also true that Min Aung Hlaing was facing mandatory retirement when he seized power in 2021. One regional envoy also pointed to how Trump had normalized complaints of voter fraud amid his own election defeat just five days before Myanmar’s ballot. Moreover, Thailand’s generals had staged a coup seven years earlier which, after a period of protests and civil disruption, had been begrudgingly tolerated.

Devotees at the Māravijaya Buddha shrine in Naypyidaw.

But in Myanmar, a defiant Gen Z refused to submit. Millions joined nationwide general strikes, doctors and teachers walked off the job, and young citizens formed the People's Defense Forces (PDF), bringing armed resistance from rural borderlands into urban strongholds. The military responded with summary executions, mass arrests, and airstrikes. By late 2023, three ethnic armed groups launched Operation 1027 in the country's northeast, overrunning more than 200 military outposts. Analysts openly predicted the regime's collapse, and rumors of an internal military revolt circulated.

Min Aung Hlaing responded with ruthless efficiency. He purged disgruntled brass hats, imposed forced conscription for young adults, and implemented a devastating "four cuts" strategy—severing resistance forces from food, funding, intelligence, and recruits, by burning villages and leveling contested zones. Volker Türk, U.N. High Commissioner for Human Rights, warned such collective punishment "may constitute crimes against humanity and war crimes."

Yet Min Aung Hlaing's ultimate salvation came from Beijing, which was initially angered by his power grab and refused early requests to meet President Xi Jinping. To save face, Min Aung

Hlaing instead flew to Moscow. “Whenever we have faced crises due to our political situations, Russia has consistently supported us,” he says.

But Asia’s superpower wasn’t going to be embarrassed by an upstart tyrant on its impoverished periphery, especially when junta-connected scammers were brazenly fleecing millions of Chinese citizens. So Beijing began arming the rebels.

A panicked Min Aung Hlaing pivoted to full cooperation with China, handing over the scam bigwigs as well as tens of thousands of lowly fraudsters. In response, Beijing has entered a cautious détente, welcoming Min Aung Hlaing to Beijing, strong-arming rebels into cease-fires, and supplying military hardware—all on the strict condition that he safeguard Chinese economic assets and rein in criminal syndicates.

“We have achieved a certain degree of success [tackling] challenges regarding peace and stability in the ethnic border regions,” says Min Aung Hlaing. “Though some matters are still being negotiated.”

Locals inspecting stones at the jade market in Mandalay.

Potential buyers and sellers at the jade market.

Myanmar's lopsided reliance on China glitters in plain sight at Mandalay's jade market. Each morning, heavily tattooed Burmese traders lay conflict-zone stones across folding tables for Chinese merchants to probe with flashlights. Once cut and polished, the jade is sold to buyers across greater China, often via TikTok and RedNote.

Mei Mei, who arrived here from Yunnan province three years ago, says she earns $150,000 annually trading jade online. Yet war has crushed supply routes and trade has plummeted. "Chinese people don't have much money," she says. "And the fighting makes it difficult to transport jade here."

It's not just Chinese traders feeling the pinch, with total cross-border trade plunging by around half since the coup. That decline stokes frustration not only with the government but also the NUG, amid growing fatalism toward the prospect of meaningful change. "The PDF are gangsters," says one dad of two in Mandalay. "Now we must pay money to both the government and rebels. They should stop fighting. Democracy is best, but stability is better than war."

Yet it’s a conflict that will keep rumbling on. Despite losing Chinese backing, the NUG controls enough territory to fund itself indefinitely via taxation and resource extraction. The harder it fights, the tighter Min Aung Hlaing turns the screw on ordinary people. TIME met one 5-year-old girl sleeping rough by a roadside near Mandalay after her father was forcibly conscripted. The well-heeled of Yangon, meanwhile, pay monthly levies to dodge the draft, filling officials’ pockets.

But across this social chasm the great unifier is animus toward Min Aung Hlaing; a mere mention of his name will elicit a sneer, headshake, or crimson jet of betel spit. Outside the country, people are more explicit. “He’s a clown,” says Mon Mon Myat, the biographer. He’s the “worst of all Myanmar’s military dictators,” says U Gambira, a prominent monk and activist. “People are disgusted by him,” says Aung Zaw, the journalist.

Unlike authoritarian regimes in China or Vietnam, Myanmar’s military offers no compelling economic vision. Min Aung Hlaing speaks vaguely about “transitioning from basic raw material production to manufacturing finished goods.” But since his coup, GDP has shrunk 13%, poverty has almost doubled, the kyat currency is 60% weaker, foreign direct investment is down 90%, while inflation averages 20%. “There’s no development focus, which really sets them apart,” says Turnell. “There’s just no vision for the economy except as a vehicle for control.”

Locals at a park underneath a canopy of trees inside the Mandalay palace's compound.

Min Aung Hlaing is pitching sanctions relief as a win-win, dangling carrots to coax the international community back to the table. An earlier bilateral agreement to repatriate the Rohingya is dependent on rolling back legal challenges, he says. Otherwise, “it becomes an impossible situation for us to resolve.” A potential amnesty for Suu Kyi “depends on her,” he says, though suggested that could change if “grounds for reconsideration emerge on our part.”

Beneath these overtures lies an enduring paranoia regarding Chinese domination, reviving the same impulse that drove Myanmar’s last, abortive attempt at rapprochement with the West. Though Min Aung Hlaing also stands to benefit personally from any loosening; he and his children have been targeted by the Treasury Department for their business dealings. “I urge the U.S. government to review [sanctions] objectively,” he says.

Such demands would be dead on arrival in an era governed by values-based foreign policy. Today, they may find a market. “The key thing to understand is, whether you engage with the military or not, their behavior will not change,” says Marciel. “That said, isolation has limited value as well.”

As global powers weigh strategic leverage against democratic ideals, Myanmar’s people remain trapped in a grim deadlock—a despot that cannot conquer, a resistance that cannot win, and foreign capitals reluctant to tilt the scales. The tragedy of Myanmar is not just that it burns, but that every player can feed the flames, while none can build a nation from the ashes.

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https://time.com/article/2026/09/23/myanmar-president-interview-Min-Aung-Hlaing/